



CITY: Pg 3
Four flagship schemes launched



NATION: Pg 5
Centre ready to evacuate Indians from Gulf



FILM: Pg 12
'Sinners' takes top prize at the Actor Awards

Iran, allies hit back on multiple fronts as US jets fall in Kuwaiti 'friendly fire'

Middle East war hits oil, shipping and aviation as fighting escalates

MPOST BUREAU

DUBAI: The war ignited by the joint United States and Israeli assault on Iran widened sharply on Monday, drawing armed groups, regional powers and global markets into a rapidly escalating conflict whose consequences are now being felt far beyond the battlefield. Missiles, drones and airstrikes struck multiple countries across the Middle East, oil and gas facilities came under attack, and international travel ground to a halt, underscoring fears that the confrontation is sliding toward a prolonged regional war with no clear path to de-escalation.

Iran and allied militias launched missiles and drones at Israel, Gulf Arab states and US military targets across the region in retaliation for the killing of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, while Israel and the United States intensified strikes on Iranian military and strategic infrastructure. The pace and geographic spread of the violence reflected the fulfilment of long-standing Iranian threats to widen any direct conflict to include energy assets, shipping lanes and US partners in the Gulf.

The chaos of the expanding war was illustrated in Kuwait, where overlapping air defences and incoming fire led to a rare and dangerous mistake. The US military said Kuwaiti air defences "mistakenly shot down" three American F-15E Strike Eagle fighter jets during a combat mission as Iranian aircraft, ballistic missiles and drones were active in the skies. US Central Command said all six aircrew members ejected safely, were recovered, and were in stable condition. Kuwait acknowledged the incident, and Washington said it was grateful for Kuwaiti support during the operation.



A black plume of smoke rises from a warehouse at the industrial area of Sharjah City in the United Arab Emirates following reports of Iranian strikes in Dubai, United Arab Emirates, on Sunday

TAKEAWAYS

» **ISRAELI** retaliatory strikes killed at least 31 people in Lebanon

» **IRAN'S** Red Crescent reportedly said over 200 people killed across more than 130 cities

» **IRANIAN** officials separately said over 200 people have died since strikes began

» **KUWAIT MISTAKENLY SHOT DOWN THREE US F-15E JETS DURING ACTIVE COMBAT OPERATIONS**

» **PRESIDENT DONALD TRUMP VOWED TO AVENGE THREE US TROOP DEATHS IN KUWAIT**

» **IRANIAN** state media reported Khamenei's wife died from strike-related injuries

» **OMAN** reported an unmanned boat attack on an oil tanker, killing an Indian crew member

» **SAUDI ARABIA'S** Ras Tanura refinery was targeted by a drone attack and shut temporarily

Casualties continued to rise across several fronts. Iran's Red Crescent Society said at least 555 people had been killed so far by the US-Israeli campaign, with more than 130 cities across the country coming under attack. Iranian officials separately reported that more

than 200 people had been killed since the strikes began. In Israel, authorities confirmed 11 deaths, including nine people killed when a missile struck a synagogue in Beit Shemesh, leaving 28 others wounded. Lebanese officials said Israeli airstrikes killed at least 31

people and wounded 149 after Hezbollah fired missiles into Israel, with about two-thirds of the dead in southern Lebanon.

The violence reached countries that have long marketed themselves as safe havens in a turbulent region. In the United Arab Emirates, authori-

Modi emphasises on dialogue, diplomacy to resolve West Asia conflict

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The current situation in West Asia is a matter of deep concern and India supports the resolution of all disputes through dialogue and diplomacy, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Monday.

As the situation deteriorates following new Iranian strikes in Saudi Arabia and Qatar, India is constantly monitoring

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CCS reviews West Asia situation, directs steps to assist stranded Indians

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) has reviewed the evolving situation in West Asia and expressed concern over the safety and security of the large Indian expatriate community in the region.

The CCS also directed all concerned departments to take necessary and feasible measures to assist Indian nationals affected by the developments.

The CCS, which met late on

Sunday evening under the chairmanship of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, also underscored the importance of an early cessation of hostilities and a return to dialogue and diplomacy.

According to an official statement, the CCS reviewed the evolving situation in West Asia, and the meeting was briefed on the air strikes in Iran on February 18 and the subsequent escalation, including attacks in several Gulf countries.

Continued on P4

Toxic gas leaks triggers evacuation of over 2,600

PALGHAR: A hazardous oil leak at a chemical unit in Maharashtra's Palghar district on Monday prompted the evacuation of more than 2,600 people, including 1,600 school students, officials said. The incident occurred around 2 pm at Bhageria Industries Ltd in the Boisar MIDC area on Mumbai's outskirts. The leak from a 2,500-litre oil tank released dense white fumes that spread rapidly within a five-kilometre radius due to strong winds, triggering panic in the industrial belt.

See P4

Investors' wealth erodes by Rs 6.59 lakh crore as stock markets tumble

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Equity investors lost Rs 6.59 lakh crore in a single session on Monday as domestic markets slid sharply amid mounting geopolitical tensions in West Asia that rattled risk appetite.

The 30-share BSE Sensex plunged 2,743.46 points or 3.37 per cent to 78,543.73 in early trade before paring losses to close at 80,238.85, down 1,048.34 points or 1.29 per cent. The market capitalisation of BSE-

listed companies fell by Rs 6,59,978.08 crore to Rs 4,56,90,693.19 crore, equivalent to USD 5 trillion.

"Indian equities witnessed a sharp decline as escalating tensions in West Asia triggered a pronounced risk-off response," said Siddhartha Khemka of Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd, citing US and Israeli strikes on Iran and retaliatory action.

Brent crude surged 7.29 per cent to USD 77.85 a barrel, adding pressure.

Continued on P4

IndiGo to operate 10 relief flights from Jeddah to four Indian cities

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: IndiGo will operate 10 special relief flights from Jeddah to India on March 3 to bring back passengers stranded amid disruptions caused by the Middle East crisis, according to official sources.

The flights will connect Jeddah with Hyderabad, Mumbai, Delhi, and Ahmedabad. The civil aviation ministry said it is closely watching the evolving airspace situation and its

Continued on P4

Orders based on AI-generated judgments will be construed as misconduct: SC

Flags growing, unauthorised AI use in official judicial work

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has issued a sharp warning against the use of artificial intelligence-generated material in judicial decision-making, cautioning that orders founded on fabricated judgments would amount to judicial misconduct and invite legal consequences.

A bench comprising Justices P S Narasimha and Alok Aradhya said it would examine the issue in depth and issued notices to R Venkataramani, Tushar Mehta and the Bar Council of India. Senior advocate Shyam Divan has been appointed to assist the court.

"We take cognisance of the



KEY POINTS

» Notices issued to Attorney General R Venkataramani and Solicitor General Tushar Mehta

» Bar Council of India asked to respond on accountability concerns

» Senior advocate Shyam Divan appointed to assist the court

» Case arose from challenge to Andhra Pradesh High Court's January order

» Underlying dispute involved a civil suit seeking an injunction

trial court deploying AI-generated non-existing, fake or synthetic alleged judgments and seek to examine its consequences and accountability as it has a direct bearing on the integrity of the adjudicatory process," the bench said

in its order dated February 27. It added that a ruling based on such material "is not an error in the decision making" and that "misconduct and legal consequence shall follow."

The matter arose during the hearing of a plea challenging a

January order of the Andhra Pradesh High Court, which related to a civil suit seeking an injunction. The Supreme Court said the case raised institutional concerns, not due to the outcome on merits but because

Continued on P4

India, Canada seal \$2.6 bn uranium deal, aim to finalise trade pact in 2026

Joint roadmap includes edu, tech, defence cooperation

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: Amid escalating volatility in the global energy sector driven by geopolitical tensions, supply chain disruptions, and shifting energy demands, India and Canada took a significant step on Monday by signing a long-term Uranium supply agreement valued at \$1.9 billion between Cameco Corporation and the Department of Atomic Energy. This landmark deal signals a recalibration in their bilateral relationship, underscoring the strategic importance of energy cooperation.

It was announced during the first official visit to India by the Canadian Prime Minister, Mark Carney. It marks a reset in the relationship between the two countries, which took a downturn in 2023. The uranium supply deal is the centrepiece of the reset in relations between the two countries. It was announced along with a comprehensive joint statement outlining the renewed Strategic Partnership between the two countries.

The uranium supply deal involves supplying 22 million pounds of uranium concentrate to India between 2027 and 2035. It includes the supply of 11,000 tonnes of uranium concentrate to India. It will be used to fuel India's civilian nuclear reactors. It aligns with the Indian government's plan to achieve a nuclear capacity of 100 GW by 2047, which is eleven times the current nuclear capacity. India's uranium production capacity is insufficient to meet the increasing energy demands.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi stated that the two countries are planning to move ahead with a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA). Once this is accomplished, the scope of trade between the two countries may increase significantly. Both the leaders



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, right, shakes hands with Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney, at Hyderabad House, in New Delhi

India trashes allegations of links to transnational violence in Canada

NEW DELHI: India on Monday rejected allegations linking it to transnational violence in Canada after a media report connected Indian officials to the killing of Sikh extremist Hardeep Singh Nijjar. The Globe and Mail cited unnamed sources alleging Indian

consular staff in Vancouver aided the June 2023 Surrey shooting. External Affairs Secretary P Kumaran said the claims were "baseless, politically motivated and unsupported by credible evidence." He said the Canadian probe is following legal procedures toward a jury trial.

See P5

HIGHLIGHTS

» Canada to supply 22 million pounds of uranium concentrate from 2027-2035

» Fuel will support India's civilian nuclear reactors and long-term energy security

» Deal aligns with India's goal of 100 GW nuclear capacity by 2047

» Prime Minister Narendra Modi confirms progress toward Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement

» Leaders target bilateral trade exceeding \$50 billion by 2030

finalised an ambitious roadmap of cooperation to shore up ties including taking bilateral annual trade to over \$50 billion by 2030.

Another area of cooperation, as mentioned by Canadian PM Carney, is energy. India is expected to increase its energy demand twofold by 2040, and the government

has set a target of adding 500 gigawatts of renewable energy capacity by the end of this decade, along with increasing the share of natural gas in the energy mix of the country. A new Strategic Energy Partnership has been announced, aiming to increase energy trade between the two countries significantly.

Continued on P4





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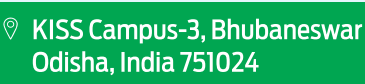
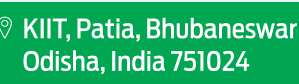
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CHAMPIONSHIP TROPHY (MEN & WOMEN)

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Participating Countries:

Australia | Austria | Belgium | Brazil | Canada | China | Czech Republic | Denmark | England | Estonia | Finland | France | Germany | Greece | Hungary | India | Israel | Italy | Japan | Korea | Latvia | Lithuania | New Zealand | Norway | Poland | Portugal | Puerto Rico | Qatar | Romania | Saudi Arabia | Serbia | Singapore | Slovakia | Slovenia | Spain | Sri Lanka | Switzerland | Thailand | Türkiye | Ukraine | United Arab Emirates | United Kingdom | United States | Argentina | Bulgaria | Cuba | Egypt | Hong Kong | Peru | Philippines | Netherlands | Nigeria



GOLD ORNAMENTS MOTIVE BEHIND MURDER; FOUR ARRESTED

Dwarka canteen owner killed, body chopped, dumped in Yamuna River

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Coveting gold and cash, a 29-year-old man, along with his live-in partner and associates, allegedly murdered a canteen owner, chopped his body into pieces and dumped them in Yamuna, the Delhi Police said on Monday.

Four people, including a woman, have been arrested in connection with the killing that took place on February 18.

According to the police, the main accused, Happy alias Suraj (29), had befriended Anroop Gupta (48), who ran a canteen at Chhattisgarh Niwas in Dwarka, nearly a year ago.

After noticing the gold ornaments that Gupta frequently wore, Happy grew greedy. He also learned that the canteen owner was living separately from his family.

On February 18, Happy invited Gupta for a party at his rented home in Matiala Extension. There, Happy, along with his associates, tied Gupta with ropes and beat him with sticks,

demanding money, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Dwarka) Ankit Singh said.

Gupta told them that his gold rings and bracelet were in his SUV parked at the Chhattisgarh Niwas.

The accused forcibly took the car keys, brought the vehicle to Matiala and retrieved the gold ornaments. However, when Gupta refused to give them money, they stabbed him to death after brutally assaulting him.

"In a shocking act of brutality, Happy procured a machete and cut the body into pieces. The body parts were packed in three plastic bags, which were transported by using Gupta's SUV. They disposed of the bags in the Yamuna river near Vrindavan," DCP Ankit Singh said in the statement.

In a bid to mislead investigators, they kept Gupta's mobile phone inside the car and did not switch it off. They also sent messages from the victim's phone to staff at the Chhattisgarh Niwas canteen asking them to close the the



TAKEAWAYS

- » In a shocking act of brutality, Happy procured a machete and cut the body into pieces: Police
- » The body parts were packed in three plastic bags, which were transported using Gupta's SUV. They disposed the bags in Yamuna: DCP

outlet and go home. Another message was sent to Gupta's family stating that he

was going on a vacation to Goa and should not be disturbed.

The matter came to light when Gupta's family reported him missing at Delhi Police's Dwarka North police station on February 23 after they failed to contact him.

After the missing report, a dedicated team to trace the canteen owner and a case was registered at Bindapur police station, the DCP said.

"Details were also shared with the Uttar Pradesh Police. Following coordinated efforts with police in Mathura district, the mutilated body parts were recovered from the Yamuna river," he said.

The police said that they checked CCTV footage for three days at toll plazas and the place of the incident to trace the victim's movement.

It was found that Gupta had booked a bike ride on February 18 and left his SUV parked at Chhattisgarh Niwas before heading to Matiala Extension. CCTV footage showed him entering a building there, they said.

Bomb threats to 3 banks, 6 schools turn out to be hoax

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: At least three banks and six schools in the national capital received bomb threats via email on Monday, which were later declared a hoax after exhaustive searches, officials said.

Delhi Fire Services said calls regarding bomb threats started coming in around 8.20 am after the institutions received emails warning of explosives on their premises. Among the banks that received the threats were the Axis Bank branch in Connaught Place, the State Bank of India AIIMS branch and the SBI branch in east Delhi's Shahdara.

The six schools that received similar emails included Army Public School in Delhi Cantt, Salwan Public School, Sardar Patel Vidyalaya, Mira Public School in Janakpuri, Ramjas Public School in Rajendra Nagar and Rabea Girls' Public School.

"Teams from the local police, bomb disposal squad, dog squad and fire department were immediately dispatched to all the locations. Every nook and corner was checked thoroughly. Nothing suspicious was found and all the calls were later declared hoax," the senior



police officer said. Students and staff at the schools were evacuated as a precautionary measure soon after the emails were received. School authorities informed parents through messages and asked them not to panic while security agencies sanitised the campuses.

At Sardar Patel Vidyalaya, the management sent a communication to parents stating that the school had received a security threat in the morning and that police teams were present to undertake necessary checks.

It added that all students had been evacuated safely. The message further stated that classes for junior school students would resume once the premises were declared safe, while examinations for senior school students would recommence after clearance

from the security agencies. Police personnel were seen conducting detailed inspections of classrooms, corridors, administrative blocks, parking areas and surrounding premises in all the affected schools and bank branches. Sniffer dogs and bomb disposal squads were deployed as part of the standard operating procedure.

The incidents led to anxious moments for parents, many of whom said they began receiving calls and messages in school groups asking them that the schools had been evacuated and may resume shortly.

Parents panicked after threat messages led to evacuations, calling for strict action against hoaxes. Police said cyber teams are tracing the emails' origin and digital trail amid heightened city-wide alertness during the festive period.

14 student protesters released

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Fourteen Jawahar Nehru University (JNU) students who were arrested during a protest march last week have been released, student leaders said on Monday, calling the development a relief for the university community.

Those released include JNUSU president Aditi Mishra, vice-president Gopika K Babu, joint secretary Danish Ali, former JNUSU president Nitish Kumar, and AISA All India president Neha, among others.

A Delhi court on Sunday ordered the immediate release of the 14 students who were arrested in connection with a protest demonstration at the Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) campus recently.

The court had granted bail to the protesters on February 27, saying that while assaulting police personnel is a serious

'While assaulting police personnel is a serious offence, the accused are students with their careers ahead of them': Delhi court

offence, the accused are students with their careers ahead of them.

The arrests followed an attempted march by JNU Students' Union (JNUSU) members on February 26, who had gathered at the Sabarmati T-Point on the campus and sought to move towards the education ministry as part of the ongoing protests against JNU Vice-Chancellor Santishree Dhulipudi Pandit's recent remarks on a podcast over the implementation of University Grants Commis-

sion (UGC) norms, the rustication of office-bearers of the students' union, and the proposed Rohith Vemula Act.

Police personnel, however, stopped the protesters at the heavily barricaded university gates, leading to a scuffle.

The Delhi Police claimed that the students resorted to physical assault, injuring several of its personnel during the confrontation, following which an FIR was lodged. A total of 51 protesters were detained.

Student groups alleged the police action was heavy-handed and said the continued detention had caused anxiety among families and classmates. Many of those held are from different states and live in university hostels, they added.

AISA termed the release a victory, vowing protests until equity safeguards are enacted and alleged NEP course dilutions are rolled back.

Case lodged against pvt hospital after part of infant's finger inadvertently amputated

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GHAZIABAD (UP): A case of alleged medical negligence has been registered against the management of Sarvodaya Hospital (a private hospital) in the Kavinagar area of Uttar Pradesh's Ghaziabad district and a nurse after part of a nine-month-old girl's little finger was inadvertently amputated, police said on Monday.

The nurse was removing a cannula from the left hand of the infant, identified as Shree Tyagi, the police said.

According to the complaint filed by her father Ankush Tyagi, the child was admitted to the facility on February 24 for treatment. On February 27, while the family was completing the discharge formalities, a nurse arrived to remove the cannula (a tube inserted into

KEY POINTS

» While the family was completing the discharge formalities, a nurse arrived to remove the cannula (a tube inserted into the body to deliver or withdraw fluids, medication or blood) from the infant's hand,

during which the alleged incident took place

» Complainant alleged the nurse used a pair of scissors to cut through the adhesive surgical tape securing the medical device. In the process, she inadvertently partially amputated child's finger

the body to deliver or withdraw fluids, medication or blood) from the infant's hand, during which the alleged incident took place. The complainant alleged that the nurse used a pair of scissors to cut through the adhesive surgical tape securing the medical device. In the process, she inadvertently partially amputated the child's finger. The FIR was formally reg-

istered on February 28 on the complaint lodged by Ankush Tyagi. Assistant Commissioner of Police (Kavi Nagar) Suryabali Maurya said that an investigation is currently underway. "A charge sheet will be submitted in court after a thorough probe. Additionally, a copy of the findings will be forwarded to the Indian Medical Council for further administrative over-

Woman's body found on Noida e-way service road

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: The body of a 23-year-old woman was found on the service road of the Noida-Greater Noida Expressway under the Expressway Police Station limits on Monday morning.

Local residents spotted the body around 8 am and alerted the police control room. A team from the Expressway police station reached the spot, cordoned off the area and took the body into custody.

A senior police official said preliminary investigation suggests the body was allegedly dumped from a vehicle. The deceased has been identified as Kavita Singh (23), a resident of New Delhi.

Police suspect she may have been killed elsewhere and her body later transported and thrown on the service road in an attempt to destroy evidence and mislead investigators. However, the exact cause and circumstances of death will be established after the post-mortem examination.

A forensic team collected evidence from the scene, and CCTV footage from nearby areas is being examined to trace suspicious vehicles. Statements of local residents and passers-by are also being recorded.

The body has been sent for postmortem. Given the suspected homicide, four teams have been formed to identify the vehicle involved and apprehend those responsible. Further investigation is underway.

Delhi Police arrest 2 for stabbing man to death in Samaypur Badli

NEW DELHI: Two persons have been arrested for allegedly stabbing a 20-year-old man to death near Samaypur Badli Metro station in outer north Delhi after an argument broke out between them, police said on Monday.

The incident took place on Sunday, and upon receiving information, a police team rushed to the scene.

"Upon reaching the spot, the team found blood on the road. Preliminary inquiry

revealed that the victim, Ankit (20), had already been shifted to a nearby hospital by a PCR van. He was taken to a private hospital in Rohini, where doctors declared him brought dead," a police officer said.

The body was later sent to the Burari Hospital for a post-mortem. A case has been registered at Samaypur Badli police station, and an investigation was launched.

"The team identified and arrested two men, Shashi

Bhushan (22) and Shivam (25), with the help of locals when they tried to flee. The two were injured during the scuffle and were later shifted to Burari Hospital under police escort. They remain under guard," the officer said.

Police said the trio were drinking when an argument erupted, after which Shivam allegedly stabbed Ankit. The weapon was recovered nearby; both accused have been arrested. MPOST

Traffic crackdown nets ₹1.69 cr in penalties

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

GURUGRAM: Gurugram Police issued 8,032 challans for wrong-side driving between February 1 and 28, collecting Rs 48.11 lakh in fines as part of a special road safety drive.

In a separate week-long crackdown from February 23 to March 1 under the ongoing #ChallanNahiSalamMilega campaign, the Traffic Police issued 14,674 challans and collected Rs 1,69,49,500 in penalties. The enforcement drive, led by Police Commissioner Vikas



Kumar Arora, IPS, and Deputy Commissioner of Police (Traffic) Rajesh Mohan, IPS, focused on violations linked to road accidents, including wrong-side driving, unsafe lane

changes, overspeeding and no-entry breaches.

Of the total challans issued during the intensified drive, 13,198 were generated through field enforcement,

while 1,476 were issued via surveillance cameras.

Authorities said monitoring has been stepped up on NH-48, Dwarka Expressway and the Mumbai Expressway using NHAII cameras and drones. Police also warned that criminal cases would be registered against motorists found performing stunts.

Officials added that awareness initiatives were conducted at 15 locations, while over 180 residents applied to join as 'Traffic Mitras', with 39 already trained.

HPV vaccine safe and effective: AIIMS chief

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Director of All India Institute of Medical Sciences, New Delhi, Dr M. Srinivas, has urged parents, teachers, community leaders and healthcare professionals to actively support the nationwide Human Papillomavirus (HPV) vaccination drive launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Welcoming the campaign initiated by the Union Health Ministry, Dr Srinivas described the programme as a transformative step in India's public health journey. He said the initiative holds the potential to save countless lives by preventing cervical cancer, one of the leading causes of cancer-related deaths among women in the country.

Highlighting the urgency of the issue, he noted that cervical cancer claims tens of thousands of lives annually, despite

being largely preventable. "The HPV vaccine is safe, scientifically validated and highly effective," he said, emphasising that systematic vaccination of adolescent girls aged 9 to 14 years can provide strong protection against the disease.

Dr Srinivas reiterated that preventive healthcare remains the cornerstone of a resilient health system. Vaccination, he said, is among the most cost-effective public health interventions, reducing not only the disease burden but also the long-term emotional and financial strain on families.

Calling for collective action, he appealed to stakeholders across communities to ensure that every eligible girl benefits from the life-saving intervention. "We stand at a pivotal moment to build a future where cervical cancer is no longer a public health threat in India," he said.

Holi: Metro to run from 2.30 pm onwards



NEW DELHI: Metro train services in the national capital will begin at 2.30 pm on Holi (March 4), the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) said on Monday.

In a post on social media, the DMRC said metro services will start from terminal stations on all lines at 2.30 pm on Wednesday. The services will operate normally thereafter for the rest of the day, it added.

On a normal day, the metro operates from 5 am to 11.30 pm. MPOST

DELHI ROLLS OUT LADLI DBT, LAKHPATI BITIYA, LPG & PINK CARD SCHEMES

Four flagship schemes launched

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a significant push toward women-led development in the national capital, President Droupadi Murmu on Monday launched four flagship schemes of the Delhi Government under the banner “Sashakt Naari, Samridh Delhi” at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium. The initiatives collectively aim to provide financial security from birth to adulthood, ensure safe and free mobility, deliver long-pending financial entitlements, and reduce household burdens through direct benefit transfers.

The programme was attended by Lieutenant Governor VK Saxena, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Union Minister of State Harsh Malhotra, Cabinet Ministers Manjinder Singh Sirsa and Dr. Pankaj Kumar Singh, along with thousands of beneficiaries.

Addressing the gathering, President Murmu said, “A woman will truly be empowered when she has the ability to make independent decisions, can live a life with self-respect, and has access to equal opportunities and security.” She noted that while women are excelling as soldiers, scientists, sportspersons and leaders, they continue to face “violence, economic inequality,



social stereotypes and health-related neglect.” Calling Delhi the face of the nation, she said, “Delhi should set an example of women-led development for the entire nation.” Referring to the 2047 goal of a developed India, she asserted that it “cannot be achieved without empowering half the population.”

Lieutenant Governor V.K. Saxena described the programme as “an important milestone” and said, “A visionary approach is essential for women’s empowerment, and the Delhi Lakhpati Bitiya Yojana is a strong example.” He emphasised that empowerment must extend beyond financial assistance to include dignity, safety and equal participation.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta termed the launch a historic commitment to women’s dignity and self-reliance.

“When a daughter is empowered, families become stronger. When women progress, the path toward a developed Delhi becomes clearer,” she said.

Meri Punji, Mera Adhikar – DBT Under Delhi Ladli Scheme

Under the “Meri Punji, Mera Adhikar” initiative, Rs.100.25 crore was transferred through Direct Benefit Transfer to 40,642 eligible girls under the Delhi Ladli Scheme into their Aadhaar-linked bank accounts. The maturity amount along with accrued interest was credited directly to ensure transparency and eliminate delays. Earlier, nearly Rs.90 crore had been transferred to around 30,000 beneficiaries in the first phase of the special drive to

L-G: ‘A visionary approach is essential for women’s empowerment’

clear pending entitlements.

Delhi Lakhpati Bitiya Yojana

The Delhi Lakhpati Bitiya Yojana was introduced as a modern, digital and incentive-based replacement for the Ladli scheme. Under this programme, Rs.61,000 will be deposited in stages in the name of each eligible girl from birth onwards. Subject to conditions such as completion of graduation or a vocational diploma, the amount will mature to over Rs.1 lakh, approximately Rs.1.25 lakh with interest, by the age of 21. The scheme will operate through a fully digital and faceless end-to-end online portal. Financial management will be handled by SBI Life Insurance Company Limited under the SBI Life Dhanrashi Sadhan framework. A budget provision of Rs.128 crore has been made, and girls living in child care institutions have also been included, with the government acting as guardian.

Saheli Pink National Common Mobility Card

To enhance safe and dignified mobility, the Saheli Pink National Common Mobility Card was launched under the One Nation–One Card vision. The Pink Card will enable free travel for women in Delhi Transport Corporation buses and will also function as a smart card for paid travel in Metro, RRTS and other public transport systems. Three categories of cards will be issued, Pink for women, Blue for general commuters and Orange for monthly pass holders, with the first phase covering Pink and Blue cards. The Pink Card will be issued free of cost, with the Delhi Government bearing the expense. Around 50 distribution centres will be set up across DM and SDM offices and selected DTC centres. The card will be linked to Aadhaar and mobile numbers to verify age, gender and Delhi residence, prevent duplication and integrate with the automatic fare collection system.

Free LPG Cylinders on Holi and Diwali

From 2026, ration card holders in Delhi will receive financial aid for two LPG cylinders annually on Holi and Diwali. On Holi, Rs 853 was transferred via DBT. The scheme entails Rs 242.77 crore annually. CM Gupta reaffirmed women’s equal role in achieving a developed India.

KV proj to boost education in Yamuna floodplain: CM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday laid the foundation stone for the permanent building of a Kendriya Vidyalaya in northeast Delhi’s Khajuri Khas and said it is a significant step towards strengthening educational infrastructure in the Yamuna floodplain region.

Gupta also inaugurated a transit campus for the school and said the project would ensure that children in the area no longer have to travel long distances for quality education, an official statement said.

The chief minister further said that a metro project in the Karawal Nagar area was expected to begin soon.

According to the statement, the total number of Kendriya Vidyalayas in Delhi now stands at 47. These schools cater to more than 1.19 lakh students, providing affordable, quality education and easing admission pressure on other institutions in northeast Delhi.

“This is not just a school but a major milestone for Karawal Nagar and the entire northeast Delhi region,” she said. The area long suffered from a shortage of quality educational facilities and was dependent on just one Kendriya Vidyalaya, Gupta added. The new school, she said, would provide students access to modern education



facilities and help create a better academic environment in the region.

Education Minister Ashish Sood and Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra, along with senior officials, were present at the event, the statement said.

Referring to previous administrations, the chief minister said schools in the area were once in a poor condition, with multiple classes being run in a single room and students being called on alternate days due to a lack of classrooms.

She said coordinated efforts under the “triple-engine government” were now accelerating development in sectors such as education, roads, water supply, sewerage, flyovers, foot overbridges and healthcare.

The government’s aim was not limited to literacy but to prepare children to face future challenges through modern, well-equipped government

schools, Gupta added.

She highlighted that coordinated efforts by the Centre, the Delhi government and civic bodies helped speed up development works.

Speaking on the occasion, Sood said the project marked the beginning of a new chapter in the region’s overall development, which faced a long-standing lack of basic educational infrastructure.

He said students in northeast Delhi were earlier forced to travel four to five kilometres for schooling and that the need for additional schools had been felt for years.

The present government, after 27 years, took concrete steps to establish a second Kendriya Vidyalaya in the area, he said and expressed hope that government schools in Delhi would soon be equipped with world-class facilities.

Mishra said the establishment of the Kendriya Vidyalaya was a major achievement for the region and alleged that development in the Yamuna-floodplain areas had stalled for nearly two decades due to neglect by previous governments.

He said the reconstitution of the Trans-Yamuna Area Development Board led to the approval of projects worth Rs 728 crore, including more than Rs 300 crore for the Karawal Nagar assembly constituency.



Public office a sacred trust, says Speaker

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Calling public office a “sacred public trust” rather than a privilege, Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Monday urged young aspirants to embrace ethical leadership and constitutional values while addressing students of Democratic Leadership (IIDL) at the Delhi Legislative Assembly.

Welcoming Cohort IX students to the Vidhan Sabha, Gupta said, “Power is not a privilege, but a sacred public trust that must be wielded for the progress of the last citizen.” He emphasised that democracy derives its strength not merely from laws but from the moral compass of those entrusted with public responsibility. Encouraging students to see themselves as future architects of the nation, he stressed the importance of humility and accountability in leadership.

The visit was part of IIDL’s structured field study programme in the national capital. The Speaker lauded the initiative of Rambhau Mhalgi Prabodhini, noting that institutions training youth in democratic leadership are vital for a robust republic. “While academic theory provides a foundation, the true essence of democracy must be experienced within its institutions,” he said.

Highlighting the vision of ‘Viksit Bharat’, Gupta remarked that India’s development is “not merely an economic goal but a commitment to inclusive and transparent governance.” He underlined that responsible legislators, efficient administrators and an engaged citizenry form the pillars of a prosperous nation. Speaking about reforms, he said the Assembly has transitioned into a paperless, solar-powered “green legislature” through the National e-Vidhan Application (NeVA). He also announced plans to develop the Assembly as a heritage site open to the public and discussed his proposal for a National Legislative Index to assess legislators’ performance.

The session concluded with an interactive dialogue, with students expressing appreciation for the opportunity to witness legislative functioning firsthand.

Property Tax Amnesty extended till March 31

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Mayor of Delhi Raja Iqbal Singh has appealed to property owners and occupiers to avail themselves of the extended Property Tax Amnesty Scheme 2025–26, Sumpattikar Nip-taan Yojana (SUNIYO), which will now remain open till March 31, 2026.

Describing it as a “golden opportunity”, the Mayor said the scheme allows eligible taxpayers to settle outstanding property tax dues without incurring penalties or interest. He emphasised that the scheme will not be extended beyond the revised deadline. The late fee has been retained at 5 per cent, the same rate applicable during the previous extended period in February.

According to official figures, 1,87,425 taxpayers have benefited from the initiative so far, contributing ₹1089.97 crore up to March 1, 2026.

Of this, ₹211.44 crore was collected from 1,34,666 residential properties, while ₹878.52 crore came from 52,759 non-residential properties.

Under the scheme, taxpayers can avail a complete waiver of property tax, interest and penalties for dues prior to the financial year 2020–21, provided they pay the principal tax amount for the current financial year 2025–26 and the preceding five years (2020–21 to 2024–25) without interest or penalty.

Over 1.02 lakh first-time taxpayers contributed Rs 395.96 crore; collections rose 49.37 per cent with 21 per cent growth.

‘Saheli Pink Smart Card will exclude Purvanchali women’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Aam Aadmi Party’s Delhi unit president, Saurabh Bharadwaj, on Monday, criticised the government’s decision to make Saheli Pink Smart Cards, alleging that this would snatch Purvanchali women of their rights.

Bharadwaj alleged that when every woman living in the city was already travelling free in DTC buses without discrimination, there was no justification for making smart cards mandatory.

Bharadwaj, in a video message on X, said, “Chief Minister Rekha Gupta is making a new mockery. She says that now women will be given a Pink Card instead of a Pink Ticket.”

Till now, any woman, irrespective of her native state and residing in Delhi, would board



“Until now, any woman residing in Delhi could travel free on buses using a Pink Ticket. They will now be required to obtain a Pink Card

a bus and avail a free Pink Ticket. However, now they will have to get a Pink Card, he said. The BJP government has

exposed its discriminatory mindset towards women from Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Haryana and other states, he added.

Raising a question over the expense of making Pink Cards, he said the government has not clarified which women will get this card and which will not.

Claiming that the government will demand a Delhi-based Aadhaar card to make the card, Bharadwaj said that lakhs of women from Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Purvanchal who live in Delhi still have cards from their original states. He alleged that the BJP was deliberately engineering conspiracies to strip poor Purvanchalis of their rights, claiming the move was being falsely projected as a major achievement when it was, in fact, a shameful act against vulnerable communities.

DDA to host Lt Governor’s Cup at Qutab Golf Course

Five-day tournament to conclude with special Saturday gala evening; fees announced

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The 26th edition of the Lt. Governor’s Cup 2026 is set to tee off this month at the Delhi Development Authority’s Qutab Golf Course, inviting golf enthusiasts from across the Capital to participate in the prestigious tournament.

According to an official announcement by the DDA,

With limited entries and growing interest, early registration is expected to ensure a full field for the much-anticipated cup

the tournament will be held over two phases March 13 to 15 and March 20 to 21 at the scenic DDA Qutab Golf Course. The event will be conducted on a first-come, first-serve basis, with limited slots available.

The Lt. Governor’s Cup has over the years emerged as a prominent fixture in Delhi’s sporting calendar, drawing both seasoned players and emerging talent. Organisers said the tournament aims

to promote competitive golf while fostering sporting camaraderie among participants.

The registration fee for members has been fixed at ₹1,100. For non-members, the fee varies depending on the day of participation ₹5,100 for Friday golf, ₹6,500 for Saturday or Sunday play, and ₹7,500 for the special Saturday afternoon session on March 14, which will be followed by a gala evening. A

concessional fee of ₹3,500 has been earmarked for non-members under the government category. Officials said the event promises not only competitive play but also an opportunity for participants to engage with Delhi’s vibrant golfing community. With limited entries and growing interest, early registration is expected to ensure a full field for the much-anticipated tournament.

MCD ANNOUNCES WELFARE MEASURES

5,000 civic staff set for regularisation this year

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has announced a series of welfare measures for sanitation workers and families of deceased employees, underscoring what Mayor Raja Iqbal Singh described as the Corporation’s continued commitment to employee welfare.

Addressing the media, the Mayor said 86 dependents of deceased employees have been appointed on compassionate grounds as daily-wage sanitation workers in the Environment Management Services Department. The move, he said, is aimed at providing immediate financial relief and stability to families who lost their earning members while in service. “The Corporation considers its employees as part of an extended family and remains committed to safeguarding their dignity and



“The civic body further informed that 1,360 sanitation workers have already been regularised”

welfare,” he said.

Chairman of the Environment Management Services Committee, Sandeep Kapoor, added that over the past year, 1,460 sanitation workers have been regularised, while 562 dependents of deceased employees were provided com-

passionate appointments. He said the process would continue in a transparent and time-bound manner.

In a parallel initiative, the MCD has announced a ₹5,000 incentive for three beldars and sanitation workers in each ward for outstanding performance in the 2026–27 financial year, with budgetary provisions already made. Officials said the incentive is intended to boost morale and recognise dedication and honesty in service.

The civic body further informed that 1,360 sanitation workers have already been regularised this year. Night-cleaning has commenced in over 318 markets, covering nearly 550 kilometres of roads, with additional staff deployment planned in DDA-transferred markets to enhance citywide cleanliness.

From alms to earning livelihoods: Delhi helps 400+ beggars turn street vendors

SHRUTI BHARDWAJ

NEW DELHI: More than 400 beggars were skilled and rehabilitated in the past one-and-a-half years under a government programme aimed at curbing panhandling in the national capital, with many now working as street vendors and linked to welfare schemes.

Under the SMILE scheme, the Delhi government trained around 400 panhandlers and identified nearly 4,000 people engaged in begging across the city, of whom about 21 per cent were elderly, an official said.

The process began with NGOs identifying beggars and shifting them in eight selected ‘rain baseras’ run by the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board, where they underwent medical check-ups, basic grooming and counselling, she said.

“Most of them had slipped into begging due to poverty, age or separation from families. Many were migrants from Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, West

“Process began with NGOs identifying beggars and shifting them in eight selected ‘rain baseras’ run by Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board, where they underwent medical check-ups, basic grooming, counselling

Bengal and parts of Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh,” the official said, adding that the majority were above 35–40 years of age. Given their age and willingness, the focus of skill training remained practical and livelihood-oriented, she said. “We trained most of them as street vendors – selling vegetables or fruits while some received training in cooking, domestic work and basic painting jobs,” she said.

Several beneficiaries were trained and rehabilitated in areas such as Dwarka and Najafgarh, where they were also registered as street vendors with the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, she said.

Registration helped protect them from harassment

and enabled access to government credit and pension schemes, the official said and added, “Once registered, they were linked with Atal Pension Yojana, Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana and other social security schemes, depending on eligibility.”

She said many beneficiaries also availed loans under the PM SVANidhi scheme, starting with small amounts to set up vending businesses and gradually scaling up after timely repayment. “This financial support played a key role in helping them become self-reliant” the official said.

Dr Shardha, who runs NGO Sant Ravidas Society in Dwarka, said most of the identified elderly individuals are

diabetic and suffer from cataract. “Many beggars survive on the food they get from temples, which is mostly sweets and due to large consumption of sweets, they become diabetic and without treatment, they get cataract,” she said.

To ensure recognition and dignity, the beneficiaries were provided identity cards and stalls carrying boards of the Social Welfare Department, she said, adding that local authorities, including sub-divisional magistrates, extended support.

The rehabilitation was carried out under the SMILE (Support for Marginalised Individuals for Livelihood and Enterprise) scheme, introduced by the Centre and implemented in nine areas of Delhi, including Karol Bagh, Dwarka, Rohini, Shahdara and Old Delhi, the official said.

Scheme focused on identification, shelter, training and reintegration, aiming to restore dignity and sustainable livelihoods for vulnerable groups. PTI

RAILWAYS SET NEW RECORDS WITH HOLI SPECIALS

Over 14 lakh travellers journey via Northern Railway in five days

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: As the Holi celebrations reach a fever pitch, Indian Railways launched an unprecedented number of special trains across its zones, serving millions of holidaymakers with improved crowd management and passenger amenities.

In Delhi, Northern Railway operated 22 special trains on March 1, allowing nearly 3.36 lakh passengers to depart — an 18.07 per cent increase from the same day last year.

Over the past five days, approximately 14 lakh travellers have left Delhi stations.

Looking ahead, another 22 special trains are scheduled for March 3, with officials actively monitoring key stations such as Anand Vihar Terminal, where additional holding areas, help desks, catering stalls, and ticket



Passengers throng the Charbagh railway station ahead of the Holi festival, in Lucknow, Monday

PTI

counters have been set up to facilitate smooth travel.

March 1 and 2 alone ferried about 15,000 travellers,

supported by extensive RPF deployment and awareness drives promoting ATVMs and the Rail One App.

Western Railway recorded over 23 lakh passengers between February 27 and March 1.

From Page 1

Modi

the developments primarily in the context of the safety and security of around nine million Indians living in West Asia. Since Sunday, PM Modi has held phone conversations with the President of the United Arab Emirates, Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, Crown Prince and Prime Minister of Saudi Arabia Mohammed bin Salman and King of Bahrain Hamad Bin Isa Al Khalifa. He said that the earliest restoration of regional peace and stability is of utmost importance and thanked them for looking after the well-being of the Indian community living there in these difficult times. “The current situation in West Asia is a matter of deep concern for us. India supports the resolution of all disputes through dialogue and diplomacy,” Modi said following his wide-ranging bilateral talks with Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney. “We will continue to work with all countries to ensure the safety of all Indian citizens in the region,” he said. The situation in West Asia figured in the Modi-Carney talks.

“The thrust of the discussions was how we are all concerned about the escalating situation in Iran, how dialogue and diplomacy should be the norm to resolve all underlying issues, and how there should not be any targeting of civilians who have nothing to do with this,” said Secretary (East) in the Ministry of External Affairs P Kumaran at a media briefing. Following his phone conversation with the Saudi crown prince, Modi said, “India condemns the recent attacks on Saudi Arabia in violation of its sovereignty and territorial integrity.”

“We agreed that the earliest restoration of regional peace and stability is of utmost importance. I thanked him for looking after the well-being of the Indian community in these difficult times,” Modi said on X. In his conversation with Al Khalifa, Modi said India stands in solidarity with the people of Bahrain in this “difficult hour”.

“India condemned the attacks on Bahrain and stands in solidarity with its people in this difficult hour. I thank him for the steadfast support extended to the Indian community in Bahrain,” he added. Iran has carried out a wave of attacks mainly targeting Israel and American military bases in several Gulf countries, including the UAE, Bahrain, Kuwait, Jordan, and Saudi Arabia, after the US and Israel attacked Iran on Saturday. The Iranian retaliation increased after Tehran announced early Sunday that the country’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei had been killed in the Israel-US strike. The number of Indians who live in the Gulf and West Asia is about 9 million. There are around 10,000 Indian citizens who live, study and work in Iran, while over 40,000 live in Israel. Currently, the airspace of West Asia is almost closed.

With flight services disrupted due to the military escalation in West Asia, hundreds of Indians are stranded in Dubai, Doha and other key hub airports, with many of them taking to social media to appeal to the Indian government for assistance.

CCS reviews

“It (CCS) expressed serious concern over the safety and security of the large Indian expatriate community in the region,” the statement said.

The CCS also reviewed the difficulties faced by Indian travellers transiting the region and students appearing for scheduled examinations, as well as the broader implications for regional security and economic and commercial activities. “The CCS directed all concerned departments to take necessary and feasible measures to assist Indian nationals affected by the developments. It underscored the importance of an early cessation of hostilities and a return to dialogue and diplomacy,” the statement said. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Home Minister Amit Shah, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman attended the meeting.

The CCS meeting was also attended by National Security Advisor Ajit Doval, Principal Secretaries to the Prime Minister P K Mishra and Shakuntika Das, Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan, Cabinet Secretary T V Somanathan and Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri.

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The increasing tensions in West Asia have placed the energy security of India firmly on the radar screen. Being a major global oil-importing nation, the fortunes of India are closely linked to the supplies emanating from the West Asian energy powers like Saudi Arabia, Iraq, the UAE, and Kuwait.

A mere hiccup in the supplies or the routes that transport the precious commodity across the globe to meet the energy requirements of the global economy can soon impact the supplies to the Indian economy.

The Strait of Hormuz is at the centre of all the concerns. It carries 20 per cent of the global oil traffic, and a deterioration of the ties with Iran can soon impact the supplies passing through this wateryway. Even without a block-

ade, the increasing costs of freight and insurance can soon impact the cost of landing the precious commodity. If the global oil prices rise, the impact would be felt in the Indian economy through various channels. The first would be the increase in the import bill, which would lead to an increase in the current account deficit. This would also lead to a depreciation of the rupee.

This would have an impact on the domestic economy in the form of higher rates of inflation. The government would then have the difficult task of deciding whether the fuel prices have to be hiked or if the situation has to be managed by adjusting the tax rates. The gas markets are not insulated from the impact of the rising global oil prices. The country depends on imported liquefied gas for fuelling the power plants, the manufacture of fertilisers, and the city gas networks. While India has been expanding its sources of crude oil and building up strategic oil reserves to navigate the current storm, it is an admitted fact that an escalation of the crisis in West Asia would put the Indian economy to the test. For an import-dependent economy, even the perception of geopolitical tensions in the region is unsettling and can create additional pressures on the exchequer and inflation.

India, Canada

“Canada is in a position to pitch in. We are a reliable supplier of responsibly produced LNG and essential minerals for clean tech and nuclear energy,” said the Canadian prime minister. In a complicated world, cooperation between the world’s biggest democracy and a key member of the G7 may significantly enhance the resilience of the global economy, according to a statement by the leaders of the two countries. Energy security and diversification are now core elements of this partnership. The leaders of the two countries are moving ahead to strengthen the India-Canada Strategic Energy Partnership and welcome the relaunch of the Ministerial Energy Dialogue during India Energy Week 2026, together with a Joint Action Plan. The areas that will be included in the cooperation include clean and conventional energy, civil nuclear, and critical minerals, with a focus on affordability, sustainability, and long-term growth. The growing stature of Canada as a supplier of heavy oil and its ambitions to be a major player in the export market for liquefied natural gas (LNG) were major topics for discussion. The goal is to produce 50 million tonnes annually of LNG by 2030, with a possibility of reaching 100 million tonnes annually by 2040. India, which is the third-largest oil consumer and fourth-largest importer of LNG, signalled its desire for Canada to be its supplier, and discussions are underway for a deal that will be India’s first long-term LPG supply contract with Canada.

The two countries have signed a Memorandum of Understanding for Critical Minerals Cooperation and welcomed India’s support for the G7 Critical Minerals Action Plan, which seeks to develop a diversified and secure supply chain for clean energy technologies and advanced manufacturing. The other MoU signed is for Clean Energy Cooperation, which outlines an institutional framework for collaboration in clean energy technologies, including solar, wind, bio-energy, small hydro, and energy storage technologies. An India-Canada Renewable Energy and Storage Summit is planned for 2026.

Among the 62 outcomes, climate cooperation will include areas like bio-

diversity conservation, climate resilience, and fighting plastic pollution, along with carbon capture, utilisation, and storage. India welcomed Canada’s decision to pursue its membership in the International Solar Alliance and its decision to upgrade its participation in the Global Biofuels Alliance as a Full Member. Carney also announced the development of a Canada-India Talent and Innovation Strategy, which will include new university collaborations in areas like artificial intelligence, life sciences, and digital technologies. Education and talent mobility have also been recognised as key pillars for the new relationship. The leaders have agreed to expand joint and dual-degree programs, enable offshore Canadian campuses in India, and revitalise the Joint Working Group on Higher Education.

The MoU between the All India Council for Technical Education and MITACS will expand the Globalink Research Internship program by allowing around 300 Indian undergraduates to participate annually in research internships in Canada.

Technology cooperation is set to receive a new injection with the relaunch of the Joint Science and Technology Cooperation Committee. With over three decades of successful collaboration between the Canadian Space Agency and the Indian Space Research Organisation, the two countries are set to implement joint initiatives in atmospheric sciences, space robotics, human spaceflight, and quantum communications. Additionally, the two countries will look to utilise artificial intelligence in aerospace technology and artificial intelligence diagnostic tools for remote healthcare delivery.

The relationship between us on security and defence will become stronger through periodic formal dialogues on various areas of mutual concern, including combating violent extremism, terrorism, organised crime, cybercrime, and trafficking. The new Maritime Security Partnership will comprise defence material cooperation, supply chain resilience, and joint defence exercises. The choice of Canada to establish a Defence Attaché in India, as well as India’s choice to accredit its Defence Attaché in Washington DC to Canada, is likely to strengthen institutional relationships.

On the economic side, leaders are optimistic that a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement will provide a strong foundation for the relationship between the two nations. With the Terms of Reference signed and formal negotiations underway, the two leaders are committed to concluding the talks by the end of 2026. The goal is to increase trade between the two nations to CAD 70 billion by 2030. The revitalised dialogue between trade and investment ministers, the relaunching of the India-Canada CEO forum, and the upcoming dialogue between finance ministers for an economic and financial dialogue are all geared to give a new impetus to bilateral trade and commerce. These will help strengthen ties in areas like instant payments, cross-border remittances, and fintech development.

“This isn’t just about renewing a relationship. It’s about growing a valued relationship with new ambition, focus, and foresight—a relationship between two confident nations charting our own course,” the Canadian Prime Minister said. In the Indo-Pacific, Modi emphasised the significance of a free, open, and inclusive Indo-Pacific region, and that the two countries would continue discussing regional stability and other global challenges. The joint statement issued by the leaders reflects their confidence that the initiatives will help rebuild trust, generate long-term economic

benefits, and contribute to regional stability and global resilience.

Investors’ wealth

Ajit Mishra of Religare Broking Ltd said higher oil prices raised worries over inflation, currency stress and India’s import bill.

Heavy selling hit InterGlobe Aviation, Larsen and Toubro, Adani Ports, Maruti, Asian Paints and Reliance Industries, while Bharat Electronics, Sun Pharma and ITC advanced. Broader markets weakened as small-cap and midcap indices fell 1.81 per cent and 1.67 per cent respectively. Across the BSE, 3,561 stocks declined, against 821 advances.

IndiGo

impact on international operations. “IndiGo has planned 10 special relief operations from Jeddah to India on 3 March, 2026, subject to required approvals and prevailing airspace conditions,” the ministry said, adding that the airline is coordinating with the Indian Consulate in Jeddah to assist passengers. Airspace closures followed attacks on Iran by the United States and Israel beginning February 28, leading to widespread cancellations across the region. Jeddah is a key transit city in Saudi Arabia.

The ministry said Indian airlines are adjusting schedules, resuming long-haul services through alternate routes, and repositioning aircraft and crew. The situation was reviewed at a meeting chaired by Civil Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu on Monday. Airlines have been asked to keep passengers informed and follow rules on refunds, rescheduling, and assistance.

SC

of the process by which the decision was reached.

According to the record, the trial court had appointed an advocate-commissioner to document the physical features of a disputed property while the suit was pending. The petitioners objected to the commissioner’s report, but the trial court dismissed those objections in August last year, relying on certain judgments in support of its reasoning.

The petitioners later challenged that order, arguing that the judgments cited were non-existent and generated using AI tools. The Supreme Court noted that the high court acknowledged the issue, recognised that the judgments were fabricated, and issued a caution. However, it went on to decide the matter on merits, dismissing the civil revision petition and affirming the trial court’s order.

Following this, the petitioners approached the apex court. While agreeing to hear the plea, the bench directed that, pending disposal of the special leave petition, the trial court must not proceed on the basis of the advocate-commissioner’s report. The case has been listed for hearing on March 10.

The warning comes amid wider judicial concern over AI misuse. On February 17, a separate bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant flagged instances of lawyers filing pleadings drafted with AI tools that cited imaginary cases such as “Mercy vs Man-kind”, underscoring growing unease over unchecked reliance on such technology in legal practice.

Toxic gas leaks from Palghar chemical unit; 2,600 evacuated

Three persons complain of eye irritation

OUR CORRESPONDENT

PALGHAR: A massive leak of hazardous oleum gas at a chemical unit in Maharashtra’s Palghar district on Monday led to the evacuation of over 2,600 people, including 1,600 school students, while three persons complained of minor eye irritation, officials said.

The oleum (fuming sulphuric acid) gas leak affected areas in a five-kilometre radius of the unit in the Boisar MIDC locality on Mumbai’s outskirts and led to the evacuation as a precautionary measure, they said.

The leak, which occurred around 2 pm at the unit of Bhaeria Industries Ltd, created a dense cloud of white fumes that spread rapidly due to wind velocity, causing panic among residents and workers in the industrial belt.

The cause of the gas leak was not immediately known.

Palghar District Collector Indu Rani Jakhar, who is personally monitoring the situa-



People move away from the area after an oleum gas leak was reported from a storage tank at Bhaeria Industries Limited’s factory at Boisar MIDC, Tarapur, in Palghar district of Maharashtra, Monday

PTI

tion, said disaster management plan was activated immediately.

“The leakage occurred from a 2,500-litre capacity oleum tank. Due to the wind direction, the smoke spread to surrounding areas, impacting a radius of approximately 5 kilometres,” the administration stated in a press release.

Iran, allies hit back on...

Continued from Page 1

In Kuwait City, fire and smoke were seen rising from inside the US Embassy compound, prompting Washington to urge Americans in the country to shelter indoors and avoid the embassy.

Iran’s retaliation also targeted the economic lifelines of the Gulf. Saudi Arabia said a drone attack targeted the Ras Tanura oil refinery near Dammam, one of the world’s largest, with a capacity of more than 500,000 barrels of crude oil per day. Saudi air defences downed the incoming drone, but debris sparked a fire, and state television said the refinery was temporarily shut down as a precaution. Online videos appeared to show thick black smoke rising from the site.

In Oman, an explosive-laden unmanned boat struck the Marshall Islands-flagged oil tanker MKD VYOM about 52 nautical miles off the coast of Muscat Governorate, killing one crew member. Omani authorities said the attack triggered a fire and explosion in the engine room. Local media identified the deceased as an Indian national. The remaining 21 crew members, including 16 Indians, were evacuated. A day earlier, another tanker, the MV Skylight, was attacked in the Strait of Hormuz, injuring four crew members and leaving two missing, one of them Indian. Iran has also threatened shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, the narrow passage linking the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman through which roughly one-fifth of all globally traded oil passes. Several ships have already been attacked, and the fighting rattled energy markets worldwide. QatarEnergy said it would halt production of liquefied natural gas because of the conflict, removing one of the world’s largest LNG suppliers from the market with no timeline for resuming output.

“The attack on Saudi Arabia’s Ras Tanura refinery marks a significant escalation, with Gulf energy infrastructure now squarely in Iran’s sights,” said Torbjorn Soltvedt, an analyst at risk intelligence firm Verisk Maplecroft. He warned that Iran appeared intent on imposing economic costs by targeting tankers, energy infrastructure and trade routes alongside US partners. Inside Iran, the strikes deepened uncertainty following the death of Khamenei, who ruled the country for more than three decades. Bombs rattled windows across Tehran, sending plumes of smoke into the skyline. Streets were largely deserted as residents sheltered indoors, according to witnesses, while the paramilitary Basij force set up checkpoints across the capital. In northern cities such as Babol and Rasht, armed security forces were seen patrolling overnight, seeking to deter unrest or public celebrations.

Iranian state media later reported that the strikes also claimed the life of Mansoureh Khojasteh, the wife of the late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, after she succumbed to injuries sustained during the attacks. Khojasteh, 78, was Khamenei’s only wife; the couple married in 1964. Reports also said several members of Khamenei’s immediate family, including a daughter, son-in-law and granddaughter, were killed in the same round of bombardment. A Tehran City Council member, quoted by Reuters via the Young Journalists Club, earlier confirmed deaths within the Supreme Leader’s extended family. Iranian offi-

cials warned that the losses would harden domestic sentiment and reiterated that attacks on Iranian territory would draw a response.

Iran’s leadership moved quickly to project continuity. President Masoud Pezeshkian said a leadership council had begun work, while Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said a new supreme leader would be chosen within “one or two days”. Parliamentary Speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf warned that the United States and Israel had crossed Iran’s red line and would “pay the price”. Israel and the United States signalled that their campaign was far from over. The US military said B-2 stealth bombers struck Iranian ballistic missile facilities using 2,000-pound bombs. President Donald Trump said on social media that nine Iranian warships had been sunk and that Iran’s naval headquarters had been “largely destroyed”. He vowed to avenge the deaths of three US Army soldiers deployed to Kuwait who were killed during Iranian counterattacks, the first American casualties of the conflict. “Sadly, there will likely be more before it ends,” Trump said, adding that combat operations would continue until US objectives were met.

Hezbollah’s entry into the fighting marked another escalation. The group said it fired missiles from Lebanon into Israel early Monday in response to Khamenei’s killing and what it called repeated Israeli attacks. Israel said it intercepted one projectile while others fell in open areas, then retaliated with airstrikes across Lebanon, including in Beirut. Lebanese Prime Minister Nawaf Salam called Hezbollah’s actions illegal and said only the state had the authority to decide on war or peace. Other Iranian-aligned groups also joined the conflict. The Iraqi Shiite militia Saraya Awliya al-Dam claimed responsibility for a drone attack targeting US troops at Baghdad airport, a day after it said it struck a US base in Irbil. Cyprus said a drone caused limited damage when it hit a British airbase on the island’s southern coast, after Britain said it would help US forces counter Iranian attacks.

The war’s effects rippled far beyond the Middle East. Airspace closures over Iran, Israel and much of the Gulf shut down major travel hubs in Dubai, Abu Dhabi and Doha, leaving hundreds of thousands of passengers stranded worldwide. Airlines from Qatar Airways to Air France, KLM and Air India suspended flights, while European governments scrambled to evacuate citizens. Germany said about 30,000 of its nationals were stuck in the region, while the Czech Republic dispatched aircraft to Egypt, Jordan and Oman to bring its citizens home. On Indonesia’s tourist island of Bali, at least 15 international flights were cancelled in a single day because of disruptions linked to the conflict. As markets reeled, oil prices surged and shares of airlines, hotels and cruise companies fell sharply. Analysts warned that prolonged fighting around key energy corridors and transport hubs could have lasting economic effects well beyond the region. The World Health Organisation urged all parties to protect civilians and medical facilities. “The protection of civilians and health care must be absolute,” said Hanan Balkhy, the WHO’s regional director, as hospitals across the region prepared for further casualties.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

STATE GOVTS SET UP HELPLINES, CONTROL ROOMS

Centre says ready to evacuate Indians stranded in Gulf states

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Amid escalating West Asia tensions, the Centre on Monday said it is in touch with Indian missions in the Gulf region to ensure safe return of stranded Indian nationals as state governments across the country stepped up efforts to assist such residents.

The Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS), which met last evening under the chairmanship of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has expressed concern over the safety and security of the large Indian expatriate community in the Gulf nations.

The CCS also directed all concerned departments to take necessary and feasible measures to assist Indian nationals affected by the developments.

On Monday, Union Minister Pralhad Joshi said the Centre is fully prepared to bring back Indians stranded in the Gulf region and is in touch



People stage protest in Prayagraj on Monday over the killing of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei

PTI

with Indian missions abroad to ensure their safety.

In a statement, Joshi said discussions have been held with senior officials of the concerned embassies to facilitate the safe return of those affected by the war situation. "Whenever Kannadigas and other Indians face distress anywhere in the world, the Central Government has

ensured their safe return. Earlier, we brought back those stranded in Ukraine. Wherever Indians are, their safety remains our first priority," he said.

Meanwhile, Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to initiate evacuation preparedness, enhance diplomatic outreach and establish an

Highlights

- » The CCS also directed all concerned departments to take necessary and feasible measures to assist Indians
- » As many as 109 people from Karnataka are stranded in the war-ravaged West Asia
- » In Punjab, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann announced a round-the-clock helpline to assist Punjabis

hubs such as the UAE, including Dubai.

As many as 109 people from Karnataka are stranded in the war-ravaged West Asia, his office said in a statement.

In Andhra Pradesh, NRI Empowerment and Relations Minister K Srinivas said the state government is taking urgent measures to safely bring back Telugu citizens stranded in the Gulf region.

The minister called on Telugu expatriates in the Gulf to make use of the helplines launched for their assistance.

Meanwhile, the Telangana government on Monday set up a control room at the Telangana Bhavan in New Delhi to assist residents of the state living in crisis-hit West Asia and their family members back home.

In Punjab, Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann announced a round-the-clock helpline to assist Punjabis stranded in affected countries.

NEW DELHI: India on Monday categorically rejected allegations of its links to transnational violence or organised crime in Canada after a fresh media report in that country sought to connect Indian officials to the killing of Sikh extremist Hardeep Singh Nijjar. Canadian national-security officials were presented with evidence that Indian consular staff operating in Vancouver supplied information to assist in the assassination of Nijjar, The Globe and Mail reported quoting two unnamed sources. India has been trashing Canada's allegations of an Indian link to the killing of the Sikh extremist in 2023.

The Canadian newspaper also named the Indian official while quoting the sources.

The report came on a day the prime ministers of Canada and India held wide-ranging talks that focused on significantly expanding the bilateral cooperation in areas of trade, energy, critical miner-



PM Narendra Modi with Canadian PM Mark Carney

PTI

als, defence and security.

Interestingly, a Canadian readout on the talks between the two prime ministers noted that PM Mark Carney underscored that Canada will continue to take measures to combat transnational repression.

"India categorically rejects allegations of involvement in transnational violence

or organised crime. These claims are baseless, politically motivated and unsupported by credible evidence despite repeated requests," Secretary (East) in the Ministry of External Affairs P Kumaran said at a media briefing.

He was responding to questions on the Canadian media report on the Nijjar killing as well as on Carney's remarks.

"India believes that concerns of this nature must be addressed through credible law enforcement and judicial processes and not through public or politicised narratives," Kumaran said.

He said the criminal investigation into the Nijjar case is proceeding as per established legal procedures. "On completion of this stage, it will move to full jury trial stage, etc. Canadians have an established legal procedure and it will proceed as per that procedure. India consistently maintained its commitment to the judicial process," he said.

MPOST

Ajit Pawar's son shares video of VSR Ventures owner sleeping in cockpit

PUNE: Jay Pawar, son of Maharashtra's late Deputy CM Ajit Pawar, has shared a purported video on social media alleging that VSR Ventures owner Rohit Singh was seen dozing off in the chief pilot's seat during a flight, and demanded his immediate arrest.

He also demanded that all aircraft of VSR Ventures be grounded till the inquiry into his father's plane crash is completed.

VSR Ventures operated the Learjet 45 aircraft which crashed on January 28 with Ajit Pawar and four others on board at Baramati in Pune district.

Sharing the clip on a social media platform, Jay Pawar on Sunday stated, "We lost our



VSR Ventures operated the aircraft in which Ajit Pawar died file

father...this pain will stay with us for a lifetime. In this video, Rohit Singh, owner of VSR, is seen asleep in the chief pilot's seat during the flight. Such negligence while the aircraft is in the air is unacceptable. This is extremely serious and shocking."

He demanded that the

Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) take immediate and strict action in the matter. "All VSR aircraft must be grounded with immediate effect until a complete investigation is conducted, and Rohit Singh should be arrested without delay and subjected to stringent legal action. This is a son's anguished appeal...for my father and for the safety of every passenger," he said.

The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) on Saturday released the preliminary report on the plane crash and said the visibility at the time of the crash was below the required level. It flagged fading marks on the runway among others.

AGENCIES

Kerala Cabinet clears land for BrahMos unit

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala Cabinet, chaired by Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, on Monday took a series of decisions ranging from defence manufacturing and sports recognition to land rights and worker regularisation.

In a major move, the Cabinet decided to allot 180 acres of land free of cost to BrahMos Aerospace Thiruvananthapuram Limited at Kallikkad village in Kattakada taluk of Thiruvananthapuram district.

The land shall be utilised exclusively "for the construction of an Advanced Missile & Other Strategic Unit and its related activities," an official release said.

The Cabinet also cleared the assignment of land to 649 possession holders in Perumpetty village in Pathanamthitta district, after confirming that the land does not fall under the forest category.

People who have been living on or cultivating the land for decades -- including those in possession before August 1, 1971 -- will be given title deeds, subject to conditions. Those who settled before 2014 and have no other land will also be eligible.

However, families with an annual income above Rs 2.5 lakh will not qualify for free assignment. In such cases, if they do not own any other land, the government may use special powers to regularise their holdings.

The Cabinet further approved revised guidelines for the regularisation of casual and temporary sweepers in government offices, aiming to reduce legal disputes.

In another decision, the government announced a job for Treasa Jolly, who won two medals for India at the 22nd Commonwealth Games in 2022. A supernumerary post will be created in the State Goods and Services Tax Department to appoint her, the release said.

MPOST

'Will never learn': Congress takes dig at PM with Manmohan video

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Monday recalled then Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's remarks in the US in 2005, describing the Iraq invasion as a "mistake", and said a government that stands up for its beliefs as well as its people's interests is also one that is respected across the world.

"That's a lesson that the self-styled Vishwaguru will never learn," Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said, taking a swipe at Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Ramesh shared a video clip on X of Singh's remarks made in Washington on July 20, 2005.

"As far as the (US-led) invasion of Iraq is concerned, it was our sincere view that it was a

Ramesh shared a video clip of Singh's remarks made in 2005 over Iraq invasion

mistake," Singh had said.

In his post on X, Ramesh said, "The PM who was singularly responsible for the India-US nuclear agreement also said this in Washington on July 20, 2005. A government that stands up for its beliefs and its people's interests is also one that is respected across the world."

"That's a lesson that the self-styled Vishwaguru will never learn," he added.

His remarks came as the war in the Middle East escalated broadly on Monday.

The Congress on Sunday "unequivocally" condemned the targeted assassination of Iran's supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, and said no external power has the authority to engineer a regime change, as such actions amount to imperialism and are incompatible with a rules-based international order.

Khamenei was killed in a major attack by Israel and the US in the early hours of Saturday, with Iran's state media reporting on Sunday that the 86-year-old supreme leader was killed in an air strike targeting his compound in downtown Tehran.

MPOST

SRINAGAR: National Conference (NC) president Farooq Abdullah expressed concern on Monday over the escalation of violence in West Asia and urged all parties concerned to return to the path of dialogue and diplomacy.

The former Jammu and Kashmir chief minister expressed deep concern over the rapidly-escalating war in West Asia, triggered by Israel-US joint strikes on Iran, and the subsequent assassination of the Islamic country's supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, according to a statement issued by the NC.

Abdullah described the attacks as tragic and a destabilising development with serious implications for peace, stability

and the security of millions across the region and the wider world.

He emphasised that such violence deepens mistrust and suffering, particularly for the people of the Global South who already face its worst humanitarian and economic consequences.

Urging for a return to dialogue and diplomacy, the former Union minister appealed to all countries, especially the peace-loving ones and the members of the United Nations, to come together to de-escalate tensions and uphold international law, justice and human dignity.

He said war only begets further conflict and that sustainable peace in West Asia can only be achieved through respect-

ful negotiations, mutual understanding and the protection of civilian lives.

Abdullah urged governments worldwide to support efforts towards an inclusive peace process that respects the sovereignty and territorial integrity of countries like Iran, addresses the legitimate concerns of people across the Middle East and rejects actions that fuel division and instability in the region.

Meanwhile, the NC passed a resolution extending condolences and sympathies to Iran on Khamenei's "martyrdom", a party spokesperson said. NC general secretary Ali Mohammad Sagar led party functionaries in offering tributes to Iran's supreme leader.

MPOST

NC chief Farooq urges for return to dialogue, diplomacy amid Iran conflict

Close Look

- » Shiv Sena (UBT) MLA Aaditya Thackeray denied any deadlock in the Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi's talks for the March 16 polls, asserting that the solo seat should go to his party due to its numerical strength
- » The last date for filing nominations for polls to



the seven Rajya Sabha seats is March 5. The elections will be held on March 16, and votes will be counted on the same day

wardhan Sapkal also stressed that his party is firm on its claim to contest the seat, but said that talks were underway and decisions would be taken after consultations.

Thackeray, in a post on X, said, "There is no deadlock

in talks for the Rajya Sabha; all parties are in communication with each other. We have put forward our claim on the upcoming Rajya Sabha seat, as numerically and in terms of the rotation policy fixed for the MVA, the seat should be con-

Sleepless nights for families awaiting their children's return from war-ravaged Iran

For many parents, the developments are scary and they are stuck in limbo as modes of communications affected

NEW DELHI: Kunwar Shakeel broke down in tears as he explained how his daughter, who went to Iran to study medicine, is now stuck in the war-torn country and has no idea when she will be able to return.

"We spoke to her on Monday morning. There was a bomb blast near her college," the 49-year-old told PTI while sobbing on the phone. The daughter of Shakeel, an Old Delhi resident, studies in the Islamic Azad University in Tehran. "She is in the sixth semester," Shakeel said, adding that his daughter was supposed to board a plane to India on Tuesday but is now waiting for evacuation.

He said the situation has gotten worse after Iran's supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, was killed on Saturday. According to officials, thousands of Indians studying in Iran are currently waiting for evacuation as the situation has turned into a full-scale military conflict.

"My daughter informed us that heavy bombing took place



People stage a protest in Srinagar over the killing of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei

PTI

around her college premises and it has increased in the last two days," Shakeel said.

For many parents, the developments are scary and they are stuck in limbo as phone and internet connectivity has almost died.

"My daughter has to try at least 40 times before a call gets connected," Zubiya Khan, a resident of Malviya Nagar whose daughter is studying in Tehran, told PTI. She said internet connectivity has completely been

cut off in Iran and parents are relying on sporadic trunk calls.

"My daughter just completed third year of MBBS and was preparing for an exam that was supposed to be held on March 5. But the situation escalated and now, they have nowhere to go," she said.

Parents said their only hope is the Indian government now and they are praying that their children are rescued soon.

"In 2025, the government launched Operation Sindhu

Takeaways

- » Parents said their only hope is the Indian government now and they are praying that their children are rescued soon.
- » "In 2025, the government launched Operation Sindhu and brought all of our kids back safely. We are hoping that something similar will be done by our government soon," Zubiya Khan

and brought all of our kids back safely. We are hoping that something similar will be done by our government soon," Zubiya Khan told PTI.

Parents also informed that Indian students are surviving on limited food ration.

"Food is limited in their accommodation. They are not sure how long this situation will last and when their supplies will be replenished. We spoke to her this morning and my daughter was crying profusely.

Everyone in her hostel is really scared," Zubiya Khan said.

Momin Khan, national representative of the All India Medical Association (AIMA) and the president of its Jammu and Kashmir chapter, said at 7 am local time on Tuesday, students from various colleges have been instructed by the Indian embassy to move to safer locations.

"The Embassy is taking them to Qom (a city in Iran). A 5-kg bag is said to be kept ready," Momin Khan told PTI. Tensions in West Asia have turned into a full-scale military confrontation, following a coordinated offensive launched by the United States and Israel on Iran on February 28.

The US and Israel carried out large-scale strikes under the "Epic Fury" and "Lion's Roar" operations, targeting thousands of sites across Iran, including in Tehran, Isfahan and Natanz. Iranian state media, along with US President Donald Trump, has reported that Khamenei was killed in the attacks.

AGENCIES

Nation Briefs

ASSAM CM COVERS FOUR CONSTITUENCIES ON THIRD DAY OF BJP'S JAN ASHIRWAD YATRA

GUWAHATI: Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday covered four assembly constituencies -- Gohpur, Bihpuria, Ranganadi and Bihpuria -- on the third day of BJP's Jan Ashirwad Yatra, ahead of the state elections. Sarma was greeted along the route by people from all walks of life, with women, elderly residents, and differently abled persons prominently present on the roadside. The CM, accompanied by party leaders and legislators, greeted the crowd from atop a truck and, in some places, alighted to personally meet the elderly and disabled. "Gohpur was nothing short of grand. Progress is taking shape across the constituency, but the overwhelming energy today was something special. Your warmth and trust give this journey its true strength", Sarma posted on 'X'.

INDIA BLOC'S YOUTH WINGS BACK IYC, RAISE CONCERN OVER CURBS ON PROTESTS

NEW DELHI: The youth wings of INDIA bloc parties on Monday extended support to the Indian Youth Congress and its national president Uday Bhanu Chib, who was arrested in connection with the "shirtless protest" during the recent AI Impact Summit in Delhi, according to a statement. The India Youth Front (IYF), an umbrella organisation of the youth wings representing several INDIA bloc parties, expressed concern over what it described as restrictions on democratic protests in the national capital, the statement issued by the Indian Youth Congress (IYC) said.

SEVERAL CURBS IMPOSED TO MAINTAIN ORDER

At least 14 injured as J&K protests over Khamenei’s killing

OUR CORRESPONDENT

SRINAGAR: At least 14 people, including six security personnel, were injured on the second day of protests that erupted in Jammu and Kashmir following the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in a joint US-Israeli attack, officials said.

Authorities have imposed restrictions to curb people’s movement, shut down education institutes and throttled mobile internet speeds in the Union territory as precautionary measures.

Officials said that 75 rallies were held at various places in the Kashmir Valley, while a few demonstrations were held in the Jammu region as well. Security forces had to use mild force to disperse the protesters in some areas.

Protests broke out in Bemina, Gund Hassibhat, Saidakadal, Nigeen, Foreshore Road and Jehangir Chowk areas of Srinagar city, in the Pulwama town of south Kashmir, and Budgam in central Kashmir -- all of which have a large Shia population, as agitators marched through the streets, raising anti-US and anti-Israel slogans.

While most of the protests were by and large peaceful, clashes erupted at a few places, forcing the security forces personnel to use mild force to disperse the protesters, the officials said.

They said 14 persons -- eight protestors and six security forces personnel -- were injured during these clashes in the Kashmir valley.

Severe restrictions had been

Punjab stands firmly with families of youth stuck in Gulf countries: Mann

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Amid escalating conflict in parts of the Middle East, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Monday announced a 24x7 helpline to assist stranded Punjabis, asking families to call 0172 2260042, 0172 2260043 or WhatsApp +91 94787 79112 for immediate support.

Stating that the state government is in constant touch with the Central govt to ensure their safe and prompt return, he said Punjab will extend full support and cooperation to those affected.

Assuring fulsome support and cooperation to the distressed families of the Punjabis stuck in strife torn Middle East, CM Mann stated, “The state government was constantly in touch with the Government of India (GoI) to ensure safe and prompt return of the people stuck. Due to the outbreak of conflicts in Arab countries, many Punjabis in these nations are facing serious difficulties. The Punjab government has set up a helpline if any person or his family is stranded in these countries they can call on these numbers.”

He assured full backing to those in distress and announced that a dedicated helpline and control room has been set up and will operate 24x7, adding, “People can call 0172 2260042 and 0172 2260043, or send a WhatsApp message to +91 94787 79112, if any kind of help is required.”

Reiterating the government’s commitment, Mann said, “We are committed to providing all necessary support and assistance to the stranded people as soon as possible.”

Expressing solidarity with the families of the youth and students stuck in Gulf countries, he said, “The state government stands firmly with these families in this hour of crisis.”

He also urged the Centre to intervene for the safe evacuation of Punjabis stranded in the Middle East.



People from the Muslim community raise slogans amid tear smoke fired by police at a protest over the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in joint air strikes by the US and Israel, after authorities imposed severe restrictions on the movement of people in parts of Kashmir, Srinagar, Monday

PTI

Middle East turmoil: Indian airlines cancel 357 int’l flights on Mon

NEW DELHI/ MUMBAI: Indian airlines cancelled 357 international flights on Monday as the operational disruptions caused by the Middle East conflict continued for the third day. Over 300 flights, including arrivals and departures, were cancelled at the country’s four main airports -- Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru and Chennai -- on Monday, officials told news agency.

Many airspaces in the Middle East region remained closed amid the escalating

conflict involving the US, Israel, and Iran.

“The situation in the Middle East region continues to be closely monitored to facilitate relief for passengers. Due to the ongoing situation, 357 flights planned for operation today were cancelled,” the civil aviation ministry said in a post on X on Monday.

In three days starting from February 28, Indian carriers cancelled 1,117 international flights to various destinations due to the conflict.

MPOST

placed on the movement of people in parts of Kashmir. The curbs were imposed against the backdrop of a call for a one-day strike given by Muthahida Majlis-e-Ulama (MMU) chairman Mirwaiz Umar Farooq.

He had urged people to observe the strike “with unity,

dignity, and in peace”.

The authorities had sealed Ghanta Ghar at Lal Chowk with barricades erected all around it, while a large number of police and paramilitary CRPF personnel were deployed across the city to prevent gatherings of protestors, officials said.

ASI TELLS CIC

‘No records on whether Sambhal Jama Masjid built over ruins or vacant land’

NEW DELHI: The Archaeological Survey of India has told the Central Information Commission that it does not have any records indicating whether the Jama Masjid in Sambhal was constructed after demolishing any earlier structure or on vacant land, nor does it have documents identifying the landowner at the time of its construction.

In an RTI application, Satya Prakash Yadav sought to know whether the Mughal-era mosque, Jama Masjid, was built by demolishing any ruins or on vacant land, along with the name of the landowner at the time and the documents granting ownership rights.

The ASI, in its reply, stated that “no such information is available in this office”.

On questions relating to the nature of constructions at

The ASI, in its reply, stated that ‘no such information is available in this office’

the site at the time it was taken under protection, any subsequent new constructions, and past disputes associated with the mosque, the ASI said that such information was not available in its records.

However, during the first appeal proceedings, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) pointed to an incident in 1918, stating that no new construction is permitted within the protected area of a centrally protected monument. It disclosed that an “illegal” steel railing was being

erected at the Jama Masjid site that year and that the department had issued orders to stop the work.

The applicant had also asked about the period of construction of the mosque. The ASI replied that, as per its records, “Jama Masjid Sambhal was constructed in the year 1526,” and referred to supporting material. On whether the structure was known by any other name earlier, the department said the mosque has been protected by the ASI under the same name.

In response to a query on the present nature of the structure, the ASI stated, “At present, it exists as a mosque.”

It further said the Jama Masjid was taken under the protection of the Archaeological Survey of India in 1920, citing a gazette notification.

MPOST

Nagpur factory blast: Nine directors of explosives manufacturing company held

At least 19 workers were charred to death and 24 others were injured

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NAGPUR: Police have arrested nine directors of an explosives manufacturing company in Maharashtra’s Nagpur district where a blast claimed the lives of 18 persons, officials said on Monday.

The Kalmeshwar police here have registered a case against 21 directors and shareholders of the SBL Energy Limited under Section 105 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, they said. Nine directors of the company have so far been arrested, the police officials said.

At least 19 workers were charred to death, and 24 others were injured, most of them critically, in a powerful blast at the detonator packing unit of SBL Energy Limited, a mining and industrial explosives man-



Security personnel and locals inspect the damaged premises after a blast at an explosives manufacturing factory, in Nagpur district

PTI

ufacturer, at Raulgaon in Katol tehsil here on Sunday morning.

Superintendent of Police (Nagpur Rural) Dr Harsh Poddar on Monday said that an initial report by the Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation (PESO) and Directorate of Industrial Safety and Health (DISH) pointed to safety lacunae at the company.

Acting on the report, the police registered the case against the company officials, he said.

The arrested persons were being questioned and efforts were underway to apprehend the remaining accused in the case, the official said.

According to police, the bodies were charred beyond recognition, and samples of the family

members were being taken for DNA testing to ascertain the identities of the deceased.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis has ordered a thorough investigation into the cause of the explosion.

Meanwhile, Maharashtra minister Chandrashekhar Bawankule on Monday said prima facie there was “negligence” on the part of the Nagpur-based SBL Energy Limited, where a blast claimed 19 lives, and safety measures were not followed by the explosives manufacturer.

The Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation (PESO), the Directorate of Industrial Safety and Health (DISH) and the labour commissionerate also failed to ensure safety practices in explosive manufacturing units in the region, and their accountability must be fixed, Bawankule told reporters here.

RDG crisis: CM Sukhu says single yardstick for states ‘Unfair’

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: After having got a resolution adopted at the state Assembly on the Revenue Deficit Grant (RDG), Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu on Monday met Union Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman at New Delhi and sought her intervention in granting a bail-out package to the state.

The Central government’s decision to scrap the RDG, based on recommendations from the 16th Finance Commission, has severely impacted Himachal Pradesh’s fiscal health.

The withdrawal of the RDG has resulted in an annual loss of Rs 6,000 crore.

Sukhu apprised the Finance minister that discontinuation of the RDG will have a far-reaching adverse impact on the financial health of the state

The state’s debt burden already exceeds Rs 110 crore, and the state’s power to raise loans is capped at Rs 10,000 crore. The hill state is in a tight situation, with little hope of reviving its fiscal health without Grant-in-Aid from the centre.

During the meeting with the minister, Sukhu apprised

the Finance minister that discontinuation of the Revenue Deficit Grant (RDG) will have a far-reaching adverse impact on the financial health of the state.

He took pains to explain that Himachal Pradesh cannot be compared with other states, whose RDG has been discontinued.

Sukhu told the minister that RDG’s contribution to the state was about 12.7 per cent, which was the second highest after Nagaland. The big states can withstand the discontinuation, but the economy of Himachal Pradesh cannot.

He underlined that assessing all states on a single yardstick was neither healthy nor transparent.

Haryana Budget proposes ‘Nari Mandapam’, ‘Agri Discom’ & ‘Vatsalya Bhawans’ for women

SWATI MAHAJAN

CHANDIGARH: With much needed focus on women-friendly workspaces Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Monday announced that ‘Workplace Safety Fund’ will be started at a cost of Rs 5 crore along with POSH cell.

He presented the 2026-27 Budget today during the ongoing Vidhan Sabha session

Besides this, new power company for farmers, introducing ‘yoga breaks’ for employees at industrial units were announced as the Chief Minister presented the Budget. He further informed that the total state expenditure was Rs 2,02,816.66 crore in 2025-26 (Revised Estimates), which has been increased to Rs 2,23,658.17 crore for 2026-27 -- an increase of approximately 10.3 per cent, reflecting the government’s balanced approach towards development and fiscal discipline.



Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Saini presents the state Budget for the financial year 2026-27 in the Assembly

PTI

Sharing further details of the revolutionary Budget, Saini said that the Punjab Police Rules made by the British in 1934 will be repealed and Haryana Police Rules will be notified.

The CM pointed out that during 2005-2014 the fiscal deficit had gone up from Rs 286 crore to Rs 12,586 crore, a whopping 44-fold rise. However, during the regime of the double-engine BJP government it has increased by 2.75 times from 2014 to 2024.

Moving ahead with prioritising women and making the state a ‘safe haven’ the state government intends to set up a ‘Nari Mandapam’ in Gurugram for women empowerment, skill development, training and capacity building and to recognise their achievements.

Vatsalya Bhawans will be set up in Ambala, Yamunanagar, Rohtak and Gurugram as integrated single window platforms for delivery of services related to women and children.

To create safe, respectful and empowering workplaces for women, a “Women-Samarth

Sansthan Puraskar” scheme will be launched, which will evaluate all government and private institutions based on a women-friendly rating.

To ensure uninterrupted power supply to the farmers, the state government aims to set up a third power distribution company in the state - ‘Haryana Agri Discom’.

As sugarcane productivity is increased through tissue culture the farmers will now be provided seedlings produced through this method free of cost.

Taking a step ahead in utilising the benefits of Artificial Intelligence, the state government has set up a state-of-the-art ‘AI Sandbox’ under the Haryana AI Mission, which is identifying and validating use cases in key sectors such as agriculture, health, education, and environment.

Nation Briefs

JHARKHAND: CALLED TO CURE SICK BOY, ‘OJHA’ RAPES PATIENT’S MINOR SISTER

CHAIBASA: A 57-year-old ‘ojha’ (witch doctor) allegedly raped a minor girl at her house after performing the rituals to cure the victim’s brother at a village in Jharkhand’s West Singhbhum district, police said on Monday. The ‘ojha’, who had earlier served a jail sentence in a rape case, was arrested during the day under various sections of the BNS and PCO. The SDPO said that after performing the rituals, the ojha had sent the complainant and her sick son to take rounds in a nearby pond and immerse the worshipped materials in it. The boy’s 17-year-old elder sister was alone at home, and the witch doctor forced himself on her. The victim narrated the ordeal when her mother returned home, which led her to register a complaint with the police.

ECR: PNM MEETING HELD UNDER CHAIRMANSHIP OF GENERAL MANAGER



HAJIPUR: The first meeting of the year 2026 of the Permanent Negotiating Machinery (PNM) was held on March 2 at the headquarters under the chairmanship of General Manager Chhatrasal Singh, to discuss and exchange suggestions with the officials of East Central Railway Employees Union (ECREU) on operations, development of railways, employee welfare related works.



Highlights
» Fisheries Policy-2026 approved; ₹3,000 crore investment, 20,000 jobs targeted
» ₹610.51 crore for rural animal health infrastructure (2026-31)
» ₹1,739 crore for horticulture nurseries till 2031
» ₹1,975 crore capital support to cooperative banks

while the Rs 1,207.44 crore Pansemal project will use 74.65 MCM to cover 22,500 hectares across 53 villages.

Among policy decisions, the Cabinet approved the Madhya Pradesh Integrated Fisheries Policy-2026, envisaging Rs 3,000 crore investment over three years and the generation of around 20,000 jobs.

A Budget provision of Rs 18.5 crore has been made under the policy, which proposes the

installation of nearly one lakh modern cage culture units and the promotion of eco-tourism and green energy-linked livelihood models.

For animal health infrastructure and rural veterinary services, Rs 610.51 crore has been sanctioned for the period 2026-31. The Chief Minister Fishermen Prosperity Scheme has been extended for two years with a Rs 200 crore allocation to support fish seed development,

training and interest subsidy.

The Cabinet approved Rs 1,150 crore to continue the National Horticulture Mission for five years and Rs 1,375 crore for the Micro Food Enterprises Upgradation Scheme. An additional Rs 1,739 crore has been earmarked for horticulture nurseries to ensure supply of quality planting material at subsidised rates.

In the cooperative sector, Rs 3,909 crore has been cleared to

continue zero per cent interest short-term crop loans up to Rs 3 lakh till March 2031. Capital support of Rs 1,975 crore to cooperative banks and Rs 1,073 crore for efficient functioning of cooperative institutions were also approved.

The Cabinet further sanctioned Rs 6,518 crore for 11 animal husbandry and dairy schemes and Rs 1,723 crore for 14 animal health and livestock protection schemes.



EDITORIAL
IRAN'S NEXT CHAPTER

The question of who will lead Iran next is no longer a distant speculation but an urgent geopolitical concern with implications far beyond its borders. As the Islamic Republic confronts internal dissent, economic strain, and intensifying regional tensions, the eventual succession to Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei will define the trajectory of the state. Iran's supreme leader is not merely a symbolic figure; he is the ultimate authority over the military, judiciary, state broadcasting, and key levers of economic power. Any transition at this level reverberates through the country's clerical establishment, political factions, and security apparatus. The stakes are immense: continuity may preserve regime stability, while a contested succession could expose fractures within the system. For a state built on the fusion of religious authority and revolutionary ideology, leadership is not only about governance but about legitimacy itself.

Iran's constitution provides a clear, if opaque, mechanism for succession. The Assembly of Experts, an 88-member clerical body elected by the public but vetted by the Guardian Council, holds the formal authority to appoint the next supreme leader. In theory, this process ensures continuity within the ideological framework of the Islamic Republic. In practice, it reflects the balance of power among clerics, political elites, and the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC). The Assembly deliberates behind closed doors, and its choices are shaped by considerations of loyalty, religious credentials, political reliability, and the ability to maintain regime cohesion. During any interregnum, a temporary leadership arrangement ensures continuity; however, the real decisions are made through elite consensus-building. This opacity, while designed to prevent instability, also fuels public scepticism about transparency and accountability, especially among younger Iranians who increasingly question the legitimacy of unelected power centres.

Several potential successors represent different visions — or, more accurately, different shades of continuity — within Iran's political spectrum. Mojtaba Khamenei, the late leader's son, is frequently mentioned due to his close ties with the IRGC and his influence behind the scenes. However, the prospect of hereditary succession runs counter to the republic's revolutionary ethos and risks public backlash. Judiciary chief Gholam-Hossein Mohseni-Eje'i embodies the hardline establishment, with deep roots in the security apparatus and a reputation for ideological rigidity. Clerics such as Ayatollah Alireza Araf, known for their institutional loyalty and theological credentials, are seen as compromise candidates capable of preserving stability without provoking factional conflict. Meanwhile, figures like Hassan Khomeini, grandson of Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini, carry symbolic legitimacy and a more moderate image, yet remain marginalised from the centres of power. The absence of a universally acceptable candidate underscores the delicate balancing act facing Iran's elite: selecting a leader strong enough to command authority, yet acceptable enough to prevent internal rupture.

Beyond individual contenders, the decisive factor in the succession will likely be the role of the IRGC. Over decades, the Guards have evolved from a revolutionary militia into a dominant political and economic force, controlling vast business networks and wielding influence across state institutions. Their priority is regime survival and the preservation of their institutional interests. A successor perceived as weak or reformist could threaten this equilibrium, making it likely that the IRGC will favour a leader aligned with its strategic outlook. This dynamic raises the possibility that the next supreme leader may emerge not solely from clerical consensus but from a broader power compact between religious authority and military influence. Such an arrangement would reflect the gradual securitisation of Iran's political system, where ideological purity is increasingly intertwined with strategic pragmatism.

The broader context in which this succession unfolds adds further complexity. Iran faces sustained economic hardship due to sanctions, inflation, and structural inefficiencies, conditions that have fuelled periodic protests and deep public frustration. A young and increasingly connected population is more attuned to global norms of governance and less persuaded by revolutionary rhetoric. At the same time, Iran's regional posture — from its alliances with non-state actors to its strategic rivalry with Israel and the United States — demands a leadership capable of navigating high-stakes confrontation without triggering catastrophic escalation. The next supreme leader will therefore inherit not only a political system under strain but also a society whose expectations are shifting. Managing this tension between ideological continuity and pragmatic adaptation will be one of the defining challenges of the post-Khamenei era.

Ultimately, the choice of Iran's next leader will signal the regime's priorities: consolidation, cautious recalibration, or rigid continuity. A hardline figure would likely reinforce Iran's confrontational foreign policy and tighten domestic controls, prioritising regime security over reform. A more pragmatic cleric might pursue limited economic and diplomatic adjustments to ease internal pressures while preserving the core ideological framework. Yet the structural realities of Iran's power system — clerical oversight, IRGC dominance, and entrenched patronage networks — constrain the scope for transformative change. The succession is thus less about ushering in a new era than about managing endurance. For the international community, the outcome will shape regional stability, nuclear diplomacy, and energy markets. For Iranians, it will determine whether their political system can adapt to a changing society or remain anchored in a revolutionary past. In this pivotal moment, Iran is not merely choosing a leader; it is defining the future contours of its state and its place in the world.

CIVIC
VIGIL



SHANTONU SEN
THE WRITER
SERVED IN THE CBI
FROM 1963 TO 1996

Democracies thrive when institutions withstand scrutiny; confronting allegations honestly may reinforce judicial credibility rather than diminish public confidence in the rule of law

BHARAT
KI SOCH



NAVANEETH KRISHNAN S
THE WRITER IS A
SENIOR RESEARCH
FELLOW AT BHARAT
KI SOCH

Tribal healing traditions in Kerala reveal a holistic medical system rooted in biodiversity, demanding urgent documentation, ethical protection, and community-led integration into modern healthcare frameworks

Judiciary and the NCERT Debate

The NCERT controversy revives an uncomfortable question — can acknowledging corruption within institutions strengthen democracy rather than weaken public faith in the judiciary?

NCERT textbook shows deep-rooted conspiracy to show judiciary as corrupt," thundered CJI Surya Kant. He issues notice, in fact, a few of them. The Education Secretary, Government of India, Dharmendra Pradhan's secretary, faces contempt proceedings. How dare he insinuate there is corruption in the judiciary? Granted, the judiciary is a respected institution; in fact, all our institutions are. To denigrate it and them as institutions is unacceptable. I agree. But are they — courts, Election Commission, SEBI, etc. — so sacrosanct that it cannot be asserted that they have corruption in their ranks?

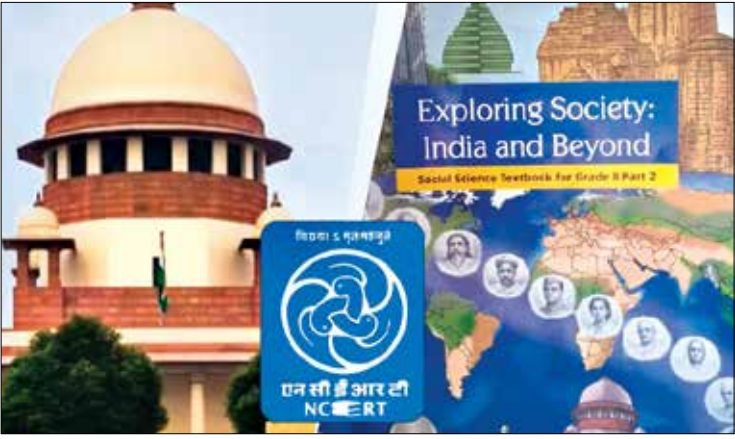
We surely can assert our will. Therefore, it is corruption one must take cognisance of. Those who hold positions in their various ranks are not all above board.

The 4 pm show, anchored by Sanjay Sharma on YouTube a few days ago, has thrown up this type of corruption in the lowest rank of the judiciary — corruption in one district of UP. In his discussion with Abhay Dube, it came up. Abhay Dube admitted to giving bribes to ranks in the judiciary and claimed the judge enjoyed the fruits. Such bribery was universal, he asserted.

In my 33 years of service in CBI, I have seen it in the higher judiciary. The book *CBI Tales from the Big Eye*, the chapter "Elephant in the Courtroom", has a tale of corruption in the higher judiciary. Let me elaborate on it.

"The Elephant in the Courtroom" presents corruption as a concrete and document-based allegation arising out of the investigation into the 1993 Bombay serial bomb blasts. Although the narrative begins with the terror conspiracy and the extensive investigation conducted by the CBI, it gradually shifts its focus to what the author describes as corruption in the higher judiciary.

The chapter points out corruption by linking it to the broader conspiracy involving Dawood Ibrahim's network. During the investigation, Iqbal Mirchi is described as having a role



The controversy over NCERT content and judicial corruption has sparked a larger debate about accountability and institutional integrity

that extended beyond criminal logistics. The text suggests that his function included influencing and corrupting elements within the judiciary. Corruption is therefore presented not as incidental misconduct but as part of an organised design.

The mechanism of corruption is portrayed as structured through an apparently legitimate commercial arrangement. The alleged illegal gratification was disguised as a publishing contract. According to the chapter, a foreign publishing house was to pay a royalty of 80,000 US dollars for the overseas publication and sale of a book authored by the then Chief Justice of the Bombay High Court, titled *Muslim Law and the Constitution* for a period of two years. An advance of approximately 25,000 US dollars or pounds had already been paid. There were also negotiations for 75,000 US dollars relating to another book.

The chapter emphasises that the royalty amount appeared disproportionate to what a foreign publisher would ordinarily pay for an academic work of that nature. This disproportion is presented as the basis for suspicion that the payment was made for reasons other than the stated pub-

lishing arrangement. The text refers to emails and documentary material that indicated attempts to regularise the advance payment by creating documentation that would give it the appearance of a legitimate commercial transaction. It is further suggested that the publishing entity itself may have been created as a vehicle for this subterfuge.

Corruption is therefore described as a sophisticated financial arrangement masked under lawful documentation, involving substantial foreign currency transactions and structured agreements. The allegation goes beyond financial impropriety and extends to the possibility of influencing judicial functioning. The narrative refers to discussions within the Bar about individuals who could influence the course of judgment, thereby linking the financial transaction to potential compromise of judicial independence.

The matter ultimately reached the Supreme Court following agitation by bar associations seeking the resignation of the Chief Justice concerned. The chapter reproduces portions of the Supreme Court's order dated 5 September 1995, which laid down that allegations against High Court judges should

be examined within the judicial hierarchy, primarily by the Chief Justice and, where necessary, by the Chief Justice of India. According to the author's interpretation, this chapter identifies the central issue as corruption in the higher judiciary. The investigation revealed an attempt at insulation that may hinder effective accountability. Corruption is thus presented not only as alleged illegal gratification disguised as royalty, but also as a systemic concern relating to the mechanisms available for investigation and scrutiny.

The chapter points out corruption through the description of a structured financial arrangement allegedly masking illegal payment, documentary material suggesting attempts at camouflage, and an institutional framework that confines inquiry within the judiciary itself. The "elephant" referred to in the chapter is the unresolved problem of corruption at the highest levels of the judicial system. Where the higher judiciary is shown in such sombre colours, NCERT boldly chose to make students aware of it. There are other instances. Even one instance blights the institution. Dharmendra Pradhanji deserves high praise.

I will narrate one more. After retiring from CBI, I worked with LG Delhi Tejendra Khanna. Here, one Supreme Court lawyer, the late P. K. Deywas, helped by solving his lady client's issues with then Commissioner of Police Dadwal. He was so pleased with my help that he narrated the tale of the corruption of a Supreme Court judge. One UP politician, Sanjay Singh, whom I charged with murdering Syed Modi, India's greatest badminton player ever, was discharged in SC because he corrupted him by personally paying the judge 80 lakh rupees. This amount was given to him by his senior, then a doyen in the SC Bar. This was in 1996.

Corruption is an issue that plagues our higher judiciary. So why not allow it to remain in NCERT books?

Views expressed are personal

Healing in the Wild

Indigenous forest medicine offers sustainable cures and cultural wisdom, but without legal safeguards and scientific validation, this fragile knowledge risks disappearance and exploitation

In the deep, emerald forests of Kerala, a profound and intricate library of medicine exists not on shelves, but in the living memory of its tribal communities. Passed down through generations, this knowledge represents a sophisticated understanding of the natural world, where numerous roots, leaves, animal products, and even rituals hold healing potential. From treating snakebites with forest vines to using ancient songs for mental well-being, this indigenous science offers a stunning glimpse into a holistic approach to health that is both resilient and remarkably detailed.

For the Kani, Cholanaikkan, and other tribal groups, the forest is more than a home; it is a well-stocked pharmacy. The range of ailments addressed is vast. Digestive issues, for instance, might be met with the root juice of the Bael tree for dysentery, as noted by researchers, or the unique tuber known as *Amrithapala*, boiled with coconut kernel juice, to soothe peptic ulcers and act as a general tonic. Jaundice finds its remedy in the dried corm of the Elephant Foot Yam mixed with curd. These preparations, however, remain sparsely documented in the existing scholarly literature, recorded by a handful of dedicated ethnobotanists.

Beyond this, the Kani tribe utilises the tuber of *Curculigo orchioides* to treat asthma and diabetes, while the Kattunaikka community prepares a decoction from the bark of *Bridelia scandens* for cough and asthma. For neurological stimulation and to treat earaches, the Kurichiyar tribe uses the epiphytic orchid *Vanda tessellata*. Furthermore, the Malamalasar tribe employs the parasitic mistletoe *Dendrophthoe falcata* to facilitate placental expulsion after childbirth, demonstrating a profound mastery over diverse physiological needs.

Perhaps most striking is the resourceful use of fauna in their pharmacopoeia, a practice meticulously recorded by researchers like Padmanabhan and Sujana, whose work documents animal-based remedies in the Attappady hills of the Western Ghats. For rheumatic pains, paralysis, and body aches, the fat of bears (*Melursus ursinus*) or tigers (*Panthera tigris*) is massaged into the skin. This category also includes the fat of the spotted deer (*Axis axis*). Asthma could be treated with the cooked flesh of an otter (*Lutra lutra*) or a snail (*Pila globosa*), with crocodile (*Crocodylus palustris*) eggs also serving as a remedy. In a practice that underscores the depth of their



In Kerala's forests, tribal communities preserve a sophisticated healing system shaped by biodiversity, observation and spirituality

empirical observation, the Kani tribe harvests python (*Python reticulatus*) fat for rheumatic pain and toothache using a sustainable method, carefully suturing the incision with fibres from the *Helicteres isora* plant to allow the snake to live on, a testament to a conservation ethic woven into healing. Other recorded practices include using Indian Bison (*Bos gaurus*) dung, boiled in coconut oil, to promote hair growth; ingesting its urine to treat paralysis; and taking goat (*Capra hircus*) urine orally for tuberculosis. For coughs, raw crushed hen flesh mixed with onion and cumin is used, and two raw hen eggs are consumed by males as a contraceptive. Further zoological treatments include using dried, pulverised leeches (*Hirudo medicinalis*) with honey for pharyngitis, and boiling leeches in sesame oil to create a sexual stimulant for males.

The approach to serious threats is equally nuanced. For the deadly menace of snakebite, internal antidotes are prepared from forest rhizomes. One method employed by the Kani tribe uses a paste made from the rhizome of *Anaphyllum beddomei* as an internal antidote. A separate treatment involves preparing pastes of *Aristolochia* species, which are often mixed with human urine, a substance believed to enhance the antidotal effect. In a vivid folk practice, a live native hen is applied directly to the bite wound in a method known as *Kozhiye vechu visham irakkuka* (drawing out venom with a hen). Respiratory ailments are addressed with decoctions of bark for coughs, or even the ash of a cockroach mixed with honey for breathing difficulties, showcasing a fearless utilisation of available resources.

Beyond the physical, this healing tradition embraces the psychological and spiritual. Communities engage in therapeutic rituals like *Chattupattu* healing songs or *Thiruvizha Chardi*, a ritualistic vomiting, to treat mental disorders or poisoning. Healers, or *Plathis*, of Kani may enter trance states to diagnose whether an illness stems from natural or spiritual causes, using a "divine stick" as a conduit. The Kurichiyar tribe uses *Pogostemon cablin* in aromatherapy for nervous exhaustion, while the famed *Sattithanpatchila* leaf (*Trichopus zeylanicus*) is chewed by the Kani tribe as a potent health tonic, celebrated for its rejuvenating properties.

Everyday ailments are not forgotten. A paste of the "Touch-Me-Not" plant (*Mimosa pudica*) or *Aloe vera* is used by the Kuruma tribe for soothing wounds. Itching is alleviated with a paste of *Begonia* leaves, while ringworm is treated with a topical application of hare excreta and coconut oil, as recorded in practices from the Attappady hills. Even concerns from promoting hair growth with a unique preparation of Indian Bison dung to facilitating childbirth using parasitic mistletoes find their solution within this ecosystem.

Supporting this vast materia medica is a crucial layer of preparatory knowledge and ethics. Toxic seeds are detoxified by specific soaking processes, and sustainable harvesting is a core principle, as seen in the python fat extraction. Wild honey and goat's milk are commonly used as pure carriers for medicines, a body of knowledge that finds mention in only a limited corpus of ethnobotanical literature.

This rich tapestry of knowledge, however, is more than a historical curiosity. As modern science increasingly looks to natural compounds for new drugs, the documented use of plants like *Tinospora cordifolia* for diabetes or *Achyranthes aspera* for arthritis gains significant relevance, now being validated through contemporary research building on ethnobotanical studies.

Yet this very corpus of indigenous medical knowledge remains acutely vulnerable to extinction and chronically under-documented, rendering its ethical documentation that integrates both academic rigour and robust legal protection of paramount relevance to the Indian Knowledge System.

As modern ethics and wildlife laws rightly prohibit the use of exotic animal products, the rich body of documented botanical remedies stands out as a fertile and ethical domain for scientific validation and commercialisation. In a global shift toward integrative and natural medicine, this plant-based pharmacopoeia offers sustainable pathways for developing new pharmaceuticals and nutraceuticals. Ethical mainstreaming, however, demands a structured and respectful framework that places tribal communities at its core. Robust intellectual property mechanisms, through community-held patents, Traditional Knowledge Digital Library (TKDL) protections, and GI tags, must safeguard knowledge, prevent biopiracy, and firmly link medicinal value to its indigenous custodians. Ultimately, this framework will catapult India's soft power by transforming protected heritage into a global stage.

The transition from forest remedy to licensed medicine requires a dual-track model, with state and private investment in hygienic, scalable processing units located within or near tribal regions, and with tribal healers guiding every stage to prevent dilution or misappropriation. These formulations must be distinctly recognised as "Indigenous Tribal Medicine" and not subsumed under Ayurveda. Such an ecosystem can invigorate tribal economies, combining product-based livelihoods with experiential health tourism centred on live preparation and treatment practices. Anchored in biodiversity conservation, this model transforms healers into stakeholders in ethno-conservation, aligning medicine, ecology, and livelihood to ensure that the forest pharmacy remains a living, regenerative resource for the future.

Views expressed are personal

AS ISRAELI, AMERICAN PLANES POUND IRAN

Iranian-backed militias join fighting as conflict widens

DUBAI: Iran and Iranian-backed militias fired missiles at Israel and Arab states, apparently hitting the US Embassy compound in Kuwait, while Israel and the United States pounded targets in Iran as the war expanded Monday with statements of defiance and increasing casualties.

In the chaos, the US military said that Kuwait “mistakenly shot down” three American F-15E Strike Eagles during a combat mission.

At least 555 people have been killed in Iran so far by the US-Israeli campaign, the Iranian Red Crescent Society said, and more than 130 cities across the country have come under attack. In Israel, 11 people have been killed, with 31 in Lebanon, according to authorities.

Iranian cleric Alireza Araf, delivering his first public remarks since he was made a member of Iran’s tempo-



A plume of smoke rises after a strike in Tehran on Monday AP/PTI

rary leadership council, said he hoped that a new supreme leader would be “quickly” appointed to replace Ali Khamenei.

Putin speaks to the UAE president — Kremlin

Russian President Vladimir Putin spoke Monday to the United Arab Emirates president, Sheikh Mohamed

bin Zayed Al Nahyan, to discuss “the unprecedented tragic events in the Middle East in the context of the American-Israeli aggression against Iran and Tehran’s harsh retaliatory actions,” the Kremlin said.

Putin noted that Russia had sought to help facilitate a settlement of the situation regarding the

Iranian nuclear program, but those efforts were “thwarted by an unprovoked act of armed aggression against a sovereign UN member state, in violation of the fundamental principles of international law.”

Al Nahyan described the Iranian strikes on the Emirates as completely unjustified, noting that the country’s territory wasn’t used for launching attacks on Iran.

Putin expressed his readiness to convey these signals to Tehran and to provide all possible assistance to stabilise the overall situation in the region, the Kremlin said.

Greece is sending two frigates and two fighter jets to Cyprus after attacks against a British base on the island.

Defence Minister Nikos Dendias said one of the frigates was equipped with an anti-drone system recently tested in a European Union-led deployment in the Red Sea to protect international shipping.” AGENCIES

France to allow temporary deployment of nuclear-armed jets to allied nations

L’ILE LONGUE: French President Emmanuel Macron announced Monday that France would allow the temporary deployment of its nuclear-armed aircraft to allied countries as part of its new nuclear strategy aimed at strengthening Europe’s independence.

Macron said the unprecedented new posture could “provide for the temporary deployment of elements of our strategic air forces to allied countries,” but said there would be no sharing of decision-making with any other nation regarding the use of the nuclear weapons.

Talks about such arrangements have started with Britain, Germany, Poland, the Netherlands, Belgium, Greece, Sweden and Denmark, Macron said at a military base at L’Île Longue in northwestern France that hosts the country’s ballistic missile submarines.

Macron’s long-planned speech, scheduled before the most recent outbreak of hostilities in Iran, was aimed at spelling out how French nuclear weapons fit into Europe’s security amid con-



France’s President Emmanuel Macron (centre), speaks during a national defence council meeting at the Elysee Palace on Sunday AP/PTI

cerns raised on the continent by recurring tensions with US President Donald Trump.

France also will allow partners to participate in deterrence exercises and allow allies’ non-nuclear forces to participate in France’s nuclear activities, said Macron, who is the commander-in-chief of the armed forces under the French constitution.

In a joint statement, Macron and German Chancellor Friedrich Merz welcomed a deeper Franco-German integration in the field of deterrence.

“France and Germany have agreed to take first concrete steps beginning this year, including German conventional participation in French nuclear exercises and joint visits to strategic sites as well as development of conventional capabilities with European partners,” they said.

Macron also announced that France will increase its number of nuclear warheads from the current level of below 300, but did not give a figure for the increase. AGENCIES

Israeli strikes on Lebanon after Hezbollah attack

DUBAI: Israeli airstrikes on Lebanon after Hezbollah attacked Israel have killed at least 31 people, Lebanon’s Health Ministry said on Monday. The Hezbollah attack and the Israeli retaliatory strikes expand the ongoing war gripping the Mideast after America and Israel launched an airstrike campaign targeting Iran.

The Health Ministry said that the strikes also wounded 149 people. It said about two-thirds of the dead were in southern Lebanon. Meanwhile, as Kuwait faced an ongoing attack, the US issued an urgent warning to Americans there to take cover and remain indoors. It said: “Do not come to the Embassy” without elaborating.

Lebanese civilians fled from the country’s south and from Beirut’s southern suburbs on Monday. AGENCIES

War with Iran will not be endless: Hegseth

WASHINGTON: Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth on Monday spoke to widening concerns that the US-Israeli strikes in Iran could spiral into a protracted regional conflict by declaring, “This is not Iraq. This is not endless.”

Hegseth, along with Air Force Gen. Dan Caine, chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, held the Trump administration’s first news briefing since Saturday’s strikes.

President Donald Trump, while he’s conducted a few phone interviews with individual reporters, has not taken questions on camera and only released two videos since the operation began.

Hegseth said the operation had a “clear, devastating, decisive mission” to “destroy



US Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth during a press briefing at the Pentagon on Monday AP/PTI

the missile threat” from Iran, destroy its navy and “no nukes.”

“No stupid rules of engagement, no nation building quagmire, no democracy building exercise, no politically correct wars. We fight to win, and we don’t waste time or lives,” Hegseth said. AGENCIES

Blood Moon ’26: Last total lunar eclipse until 2029 arrives today

On Tuesday evening, a dark shadow will begin to sweep across bright & round full Moon

MELBOURNE: On Tuesday March 3, the Moon will pass directly through Earth’s shadow, creating a total lunar eclipse. Best of all, Australia and Aotearoa New Zealand are in a prime position to watch the show.

This time, the eclipse even occurs at a reasonable hour – no need to set an alarm and crawl out of bed at a ridiculous time.

On Tuesday evening, a dark shadow will begin to sweep across the bright and round full Moon. Once the Moon becomes fully immersed in shadow, it will take on a reddish glow. Astronomers call this “totality”. But with the ominous appearance of a red Moon hanging large in the sky, it’s no wonder that throughout



Takeaways

- » Once the Moon becomes fully immersed in shadow, it will take on a reddish glow
- » Watching a lunar eclipse is a reminder that we are part of a fascinating universe

history and across cultures it was seen as a portent of evil. In today’s world, the name “blood moon” has readily captured public imagination.

Watching a lunar eclipse is a reminder that we are part of a fascinating universe. No

special equipment is needed and it’s usually not hard to find the Moon in the sky. Tomorrow’s eclipse will be our last chance to see a blood moon until 2029, when it will ring in the New Year in the early hours of January 1.

as the partial eclipse phase. This will be followed by an hour of totality when the Moon turns red, and then another 75 minutes as the Moon emerges out of the shadow and returns to full brightness.

Since Earth’s shadow is so large compared to the Moon, everyone on our planet’s night side experiences a lunar eclipse at exactly the same time. To know when to see the totality, we only need to make adjustments for different time zones.

Across most of Western Australia the eclipse begins with the Moon below the horizon. As the Moon rises it will be partly in shadow, making it hard to spot, especially against the bright twilight sky (noting that the Moon is rising as the Sun is setting).

However, just give it some time and the eclipsed Moon will become easier to see as it climbs higher in the east and twilight gives way to night.

The eclipse will start later in the evening across the rest of Australia, with the Moon in the eastern sky.

In New Zealand the eclipse will begin much later at 10:50pm local time. That will provide the best views, as the sky will be well and truly dark, and the Moon will be high in the north.

Why does the Moon turn red?

Against the bright Moon, Earth’s shadow appears black at first. It’s only when the Moon is fully immersed in shadow that the reddish “blood moon” glow becomes apparent. AGENCIES

Sport

Wankhede calling

Suryakumar Yadav needs to seize the moment as a batter too

S KANNAN

NEW DELHI: The smile on Suryakumar Yadav’s face and his animated celebration with Sanju Samson after India defeated West Indies to reach the ICC T20 World Cup semi-finals in Kolkata on Sunday made for good television. Interestingly, this was the same Samson whose place in the side had come under scrutiny last week, when Suryakumar was asked at a press conference whether changes were needed as Abhishek Sharma struggled for form.

It is now evident that while Abhishek continues to be backed publicly, the dip in his confidence is visible. Dropping catches as if butter has been applied to his fingers is not a pleasant sight and reflects the pressure he is under.

As Team India landed in Mumbai on Monday, the focus shifted to the Wankhede Stadium — the venue where India defeated the United States last month. On that occasion, Suryakumar scored a match-winning 84. Since then, however, he has struggled for substantial scores. A glance at his numbers in this World Cup suggests a skipper short of fluency. He has been reprieved



Suryakumar Yadav bows to Sanju Samson after the win over West Indies PTI

early in innings more than once, yet has failed to convert starts into defining knocks.

Against West Indies on Sunday, Suryakumar attempted to play more authentic strokes through the off-side, but his inability to register a half-century in a crucial chase adds to the impression that he is not at

his dominant best.

The Wankhede is a happy hunting ground for India — and for Suryakumar personally. This is home. He grew up playing ‘Maidan’ cricket in Mumbai and knows these conditions intimately. Familiar surroundings, positive vibes and passionate home support could

38.5
Suryakumar’s T20 World Cup numbers are worrying. He has an average of 38.50 and a strike-rate of 135.88

provide the lift he needs when India take on England in the semi-final on March 5, a day after Holi.

So far, India’s campaign has been sustained by different match-winners — Ishan Kishan, Abhishek Sharma, Hardik Pandya and Sanju Samson have all stepped up at various stages. Now, it is time for Suryakumar to do the same. At this stage of the tournament, every game is a knockout. Perform or perish is the mantra. India had to beat West Indies and managed to do so against the odds.

England may appear light on paper, but in T20 cricket they are never to be underes-

timated. On their day, they can be formidable.

Suryakumar continues to wear a cheerful expression outwardly, but he will know that his bat has not spoken loudly enough. For someone once celebrated as a 360-degree batter, his returns have been modest. Scores of 30 or 35 are not what one expects from the captain in a World Cup. He must now change gears and produce a defining innings — particularly with potentially just two matches left in the tournament.

At 35, Suryakumar understands this World Cup could represent his defining opportunity as a leader. With the next T20 World Cup scheduled for 2028 in Australia and England, the BCCI is certain to look ahead and groom younger leaders. The T20 format’s growing significance adds further urgency. India will compete in the Asian Games in Nagoya this September, and T20 cricket will feature in the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. The clock is ticking.

If stalwarts like Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli moved on after India’s 2024 World Cup triumph, Suryakumar knows how the system functions. Transition planning is constant. Grooming new leaders is now part of the blueprint.

‘THOUGHT HE NEVER ACCELERATED’

Beyond Samson’s 97: How India’s collective spark lit up Eden

MEENAKSHI RAO

KOLKATA: At Eden Gardens — where chases gather momentum as swiftly as the outfield — India’s march into the semi-finals of the ICC Men’s T20 World Cup 2026 was defined not only by Sanju Samson’s silken 97, but also by the quieter, decisive moments that made it possible.

For head coach Gautam Gambhir, the turning point arrived in a brief passage of play when Shivam Dube struck two boundaries to ease the mounting pressure of a stiff chase.

“For me, Shivam’s two boundaries are as important as Sanju’s 97,” Gambhir said. “If he hadn’t hit those two boundaries, you probably wouldn’t even be talking about that 97.”

That philosophy of collective contribution framed India’s performance. Samson’s innings, elegant as it was, never felt like an act of reckless acceleration.

“I actually thought he never accelerated the innings,” Gambhir observed. “It was just very, very normal cricketing shots. I never saw any muscling of the ball.”

In a high-pressure pursuit of 196, Samson’s mastery lay in his control of tempo — shifting gears subtly without ever appearing hurried. His com-



Gautam Gambhir embraces Sanju Samson PTI

“We always knew the talent Sanju had... three T20 hundreds — not many people have that

Gautam Gambhir, India’s coach

posure ensured India remained within touching distance of the target at every stage.

Gambhir’s faith in Samson through a lean patch earlier in the tournament was emphatically vindicated.

“We always knew the talent Sanju had... three T20 hun-

dreds — not many people have that. We knew whenever we needed him in a World Cup game, he would deliver,” he said.

The foundation for the chase, however, had been laid earlier with the ball. West Indies’ most consistent batter in the tournament, Shai Hope, was kept quiet during the powerplay — a phase Gambhir identified as critical.

“When you play a game of this magnitude, you’ve got to start really well with the new ball,” he said, highlighting the early overs bowled by Arshdeep Singh and Hardik Pandya.

The decision to deploy Axar Patel twice in the powerplay, on a surface not typically conducive to spin, proved equally pivotal.



West Indies’ Shai Hope is bowled out PTI

As Windies pick up the pieces, Hope finds progress in elimination

MEENAKSHI RAO

KOLKATA: The night ended in elimination, but West Indies captain Shai Hope chose reflection over regret. In a calm and candid press conference at Eden Gardens, he framed his side’s T20 World Cup exit as a story of progress — one defined by growth, yet undone by a handful of decisive moments.

Hope’s central theme was

development, particularly with the ball. He highlighted a campaign in which West Indies consistently struck during the powerplay, calling it “outstanding” that the bulk of their wickets in the group stage came inside the first six overs.

The new-ball pairing set the tone, the spinners controlled the middle overs, and roles were clearly defined. “We were very precise with the way

we wanted to go about playing against each opposition,” he said, stressing that planning and match-ups had finally begun to align with on-field execution.

There were positives with the bat as well. Shimron Hetmyer’s promotion to No. 3 injected impetus, and contributions came from across the order through the tournament. Even on the night of elimina-

tion, Hope pointed to 45 without loss in the powerplay as a platform — short of the 65–70 they ideally target, but a base from which a stronger push should have emerged.

“Execution in the powerplay from the batting side wasn’t as we wanted,” he admitted, returning to his recurring theme: fine margins.

Those margins were further narrowed by conditions.

Dew at Eden Gardens tilted the contest in favour of the chasing side, and a string of lost tosses meant West Indies were repeatedly forced to bowl second. Plans — such as using Akeal Hosein’s control early and exploiting left-right matchups — were sound, Hope maintained, but far more difficult to execute once the ball grew slick and the surface eased.

He was generous in

acknowledging the opposition, singling out Sanju Samson for a “very smart and calculated” innings that merited “an A-plus.” Yet Hope did not shy away from self-assessment. He conceded that his own tempo at the top could have been sharper and that he “didn’t get going” despite feeling he struck the ball well.

Ultimately, the tone was forward-looking.

WEST AISA CONFLICT

Natanz nuclear site hit in US-Israeli strikes: Iran’s nuclear ambassador

VIENNA: Iran’s Ambassador to the International Atomic Energy Agency on Monday alleged that airstrikes by the United States and Israel targeted the Natanz enrichment facility in his country. That contradicts an assessment by the UN nuclear watchdog chief, Rafael Grossi, who said that “up to now” the agency has “no indication” that nuclear facilities have been hit in Iran. “Again, they attacked Iran’s peaceful safeguarded nuclear facilities yesterday. Their justification that Iran wants to develop nuclear weapons is simply a big lie,” Reza Najafi told reporters at the IAEA headquarters in Vienna, where a special session of the Board of Governors is being held at the request of Russia.

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER
Assistant Signal and Telecom Engineer/ TM/Garden Reach, South Eastern Railway acting for and on behalf of the President of India invites e-tender for the following work : **Tender No: TM-GRC-SNT-NEW-CH-HQ-2026**; Description of work : Supply, Installation, Testing and commissioning of Telecom facility at New Conference Hall for the officers’ Zonal Headquarters, South Eastern Railway; **Advertised Value** : ₹ 1,24,50,483.46; **Earnest Money** : ₹ 2,12,300.00; **Cost of tender documents** : NIL; **Date of closing of tender** : 24/03/2026 at 15:00 hrs.; **Completion period** : 09 Months; **Closing Date/Time** : 24/03/2026 at 15:00 hrs. Detailed Tender Notice is also available on website : www.ireps.gov.in (PR-1257)

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASTRA
Public Works Division, Dharashiv
E-Tender Notice No. 18/2025 -2026 Second Call
Online Tenders Works are invited by the Executive Engineer, Public Works Division, Dharashiv (Phone No. 02472-222882/83) in B-1 from eligible contractors.
Website <http://mahatenders.gov.in> & <https://pwd.maharashtra.gov.in> .
Sd/-
(S.J.Ket)
Executive Engineer
Public Works Division,
Dharashiv
DGIPR/2025-26/6265

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-Procurement Tender Notice No. JHS/DYCM/2026/21 Date : 01.03.2026
E-Procurement Tender Notice
On behalf of the President of India, Dy. Chief Materials Manager, Office North Central Railway, Jhansi, invites the following E-procurement Tenders.
S.N.: 1 Tender No.: 51256329 Earnest money Deposit (₹) : 9.52,300/-
Short Description : Supply of Roof Mounted AC Package Unit (RMPU) Type-I for LHB EOG Coaches in Coach Set, Consisting of RMPU with R407c refrigerant-02 Nos. to the RDSO Specification No. RDSO/PE/SPEC/AC/0061-2005 Rev. 2, ALONG WITH DRG NO. RDSO/PE/SK/AC/0069-2004, REV-3 and Microprocessor Controller unit-01 No. as per RDSO Specification no. RDSO/PE/SPEC/AC/0139-2009 Rev. 1 or latest, Type -1 Complete with accessories as per scope of supply as envisaged in the RDSO specification with Supply of bellows set consisting of 01 No. Supply Air Bellow, 02 Nos Fresh Air Bellows & 02 Nos. Return Air Bellows Ducts made of Meta Aramid / Para Aramid fabric with silicone rubber coating on both sides for LHB EOG/HOG type AC Coaches as per RDSO Specification no. RDSO/PE/SPEC/AC/0197-2020.(Rev-0) or latest Scope of Supply as per clause no. 2 of the above specification. One coach set is 02 nos. Roof mounted AC package Units.
Purchase Qty.: 10 Set Tender Opening Date : 18.03.2026
Short Description : Supply of Roof Mounted AC Package Unit (RMPU) Type-I for LHB EOG Coaches in Coach Set, Consisting of RMPU with R407c refrigerant-02 Nos. to the RDSO Specification No. RDSO/PE/SPEC/AC/0061-2005 Rev. 2, ALONG WITH DRG NO. RDSO/PE/SK/AC/0069-2004, REV-3 and Microprocessor Controller unit-01 No. as per RDSO Specification no. RDSO/PE/SPEC/AC/0139-2009 Rev. 1 or latest, Type -1 Complete with accessories as per scope of supply as envisaged in the RDSO specification with Supply of bellows set consisting of 01 No. Supply Air Bellow, 02 Nos Fresh Air Bellows & 02 Nos. Return Air Bellows Ducts made of Meta Aramid / Para Aramid fabric with silicone rubber coating on both sides for LHB EOG/HOG type AC Coaches as per RDSO Specification no. RDSO/PE/SPEC/AC/0197-2020.(Rev-0) or latest. Scope of Supply as per clause no. 2 of the above specification. One coach set is 02 nos. Roof mounted AC package Units
Purchase Qty.: 10 Set Tender Opening Date : 18.03.2026
S.N.: 2 Tender No.: 51265129 Earnest money Deposit (₹) : 1,90,450/-
Short Description : 500KVA (336KW)/750V,3PH DIESEL ALTERNATOR SET FOR LHB POWER CAR WITHOUT POWER AND CONTROL PANEL & CONFORMING TO LATEST CP&CB EMISSION NORMS, WITH NOISE REDUCTION FEATURES WITHOUT ACOUSTIC PANELS., as per Drawing: RDSO/PE/SPEC/AC/0084-2008, REV-1, WITH RCF ANNEXURE-A ALONG WITH NOISE REDUCTION FEATURES AS PER RDSO MODIFICATION SHEET No. RDSO/PE/MS/AC/0045-2008, REV-0, AM-1 WITH RCF ANNEXURE-C WITH REMOTE MONITORING SYSTEM AS PER MCF/RBL MEDTS-0006 REV 0., Packing Instruction: AS PER STANDARD PACKING. IT SHOULD BE ENSURED THAT ITEM SHOULD NOT RUB DURING TRANSPORTATION. THE ITEM SHOULD BE PACKED WITH ADEQUATE STRENGTH. TRANSIT DAMAGE, IF ANY, SHALL BEAT THE COST OF SUPPLIER.
Purchase Qty.: 02 Nos Tender Opening Date : 09.03.2026
Note:- The Complete information of above tenders can be seen and download from IREPS website i.e. <https://www.ireps.gov.in>. For any change/corrigendum in tender, please visit this website regularly. No separate corrigendum/change will be published in news paper. 486126 (MG)
North central railways @ CPONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

IMPORTANT NOTICE
On the occasion of 'HOLI' festival on 04.03.2026 (Wednesday) following arrangements have been made regarding working of PRS Locations of Delhi area under the administrative control of CCMPM.
(A) Skeleton services will be available from (8.00 hrs to 14.00 hrs) at following locations. These PRS Locations will function as usual in the Evening shift (14.00 to 20.00 hrs).
(i) IRCA Reservation Complex (ii) Delhi/PRS & (iii) Hazrat Nizamuddin/PRS.
(B) Following Reservation Offices will remain closed in the Morning Shift (08.00 hrs to 14.00 hrs). All these PRS Locations will function as usual in the Evening shift (14.00 to 20.00 hrs).
(i) Sarojini Nagar (ii) Lajpat Nagar (iii) Okhla (iv) Karkardooma (v) Delhi Shahadra (vi) Adarsh Nagar (vii) Subzi Mandi (viii) Kirti Nagar (ix) Tughlakabad (x) Shakur Basti (xi) Rohini (xii) All India Institute of Medical Sciences (xiii) Ghaziabad (xiv) Noida (xv) International Tourist Bureau (ITB) IRCA.
(C) Following Reservation Offices will remain closed for the whole day:-
(i) Parliament House (ii) Press Club of India (iii) Railway Board (iv) Supreme Court (v) High Court and (Vi) Jawahar Lal Nehru University.
PRS counters will remain closed on 04.03.2026 (Wednesday) in the Morning shift (08:00 hrs. to 14:00 hrs) on the occasion of HOLI at following locations over Delhi Division i.e. Anand Vihar Terminal (PRS), Sahibabad, Naya Ghaziabad, Gurgaon, Palam, Delhi Cantt., Delhi Sarai Rohilla, Faridabad, Ballabhgarh, Palwal, Narela, Sonipat, Panipat, Karnal, Kurukshetra, Jind, Mansa, Rohtak, Bahadur Garh, Nangloi, Shamlu, Murad Nagar, Modi Nagar, Maur, Meerut Cantt., Meerut City, Muzaffar Nagar, Khatauli, Deoband, Darul Uloom, Baraut, Gohana, Pataudi Road, Greater Noida, Noli, Saket Court, Dwarka Court, Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT), Shakur Basti, Samalkha, Ganaur, Shahabad Markanda, Tohana, Tapri, Narwana, Chaudhary Charan Singh University (MTC).
Current Reservation counters at New Delhi (Pahar Ganj & Ajmeri Gate Side), Delhi Main, Hazrat Nizamuddin, Anand Vihar & Delhi Sarai Rohilla Railway Stations will work at usual timing.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 BNSS
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Panna Singh, S/o: Sh. Deepa Singh, R/o: House No. D-17, Mansarovar Park, Shahdara, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 418/2017, U/s: 380/411 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Timarpur, Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Panna Singh**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Panna Singh**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Panna Singh, FIR No. 418/2017, U/s: 380/411 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Timarpur, Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **07.04.2026**.
By Order
Sh. Karanbir Singh, LD.
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
District Central, Room No. 26
Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi
DP/2693/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Jatin, S/o: Lekhraj, R/o: 16/115, I Block, Hardhyan Singh Marg, Bapa Nagar, Karol Bagh, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 393/2022, U/s: 138 NI Act, PS: Karol Bagh, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Jatin**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Jatin**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Jatin**, of **FIR No. 393/2022, U/s: 138 NI Act, PS: Karol Bagh, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.04.2026**.
By Order
Nishant Bangarh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01
(Central) Room No. 180
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi
DP/2491/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to inform the public at large that M/s Meriton Infotech Pvt. Ltd. has been accorded Environmental Clearance from MoEF&CC (EC File No. 21-222/2007-IA.III; dated 22.01.2008) for the development of IT Campus at Plot No. B-9/A, Sector-62, Noida, Uttar Pradesh.
MERITON INFOTECH PVT. LTD.
Registered Office: CTS-102, Sani Armaa Raut Lane, Near Iskcon Temple, Juhu Vile Parle West Mumbai-400049
NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
No. T_24-25 Upgrade_ toilet_RT, Date- 01.03.2026
Corrigendum
Corrigendum to Tender Notice No. T_24-25 Upgrade_ toilet_RT, Date- 13.02.2026
Description- Tender Closing Date & Time- Published date and time: 16.03.2026, 15.30 Modified date and time: 26.03.2026, 15.30 Bidding Start Date- Published date and time: 02.03.2026 Modified date and time: 12.03.2026
Note:- All other terms and conditions remain the same. 345/26 FA
North central railways @CPONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

कार्यालय नगर पालिक निगम, खण्डवा (म.प्र.)
खण्डवा, दिनांक 24/02/2026
ई-निविदा विज्ञप्ति
निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु निविदा ऑनलाईन आमंत्रित की जाती है, निम्नलिखित कार्य की निविदा का विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाईट <http://www.mptenders.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।

क्र	ऑनलाईन पोर्टल	कार्य का नाम	अनुमानित लागत (लाख में)	घरोहर राशि	निविदा प्रपत्र की राशि	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि
1.	2026 UAD 484922_1	Electrification work, supply Installation & Commissioning of HVAC System, Firefighting & Fire Alarm System, CCTV & Server, Rainwater Harvesting and Lift in New office Building	547.62 Lacs	2,73,808/-	20,000/-	01 Month

1. निविदा ऑनलाईन क्रय एवं प्रस्तुत करने की अंतिम तिथि : 26/03/2028 (शाम 5.30 बजे तक)
2. निविदा खोलने की दिनांक : 28/03/2026 (प्रातः 10.30 बजे)
निविदा संबंधी समस्त जानकारी वेबसाईट <http://www.mptenders.gov.in> पर देखी जा सकती है। निविदा में यदि किसी भी प्रकार का संशोधन किया जाता है तो वह समाचार पत्र में प्रकाशित नहीं किया जायेगा।
उपयुक्त
नगर पालिक निगम, खण्डवा

CHHATTISGARH STATE POWER TRANS. CO. LTD.
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CIN- U40108CT2003SGCO15820 / GSTIN-22AAADCC5773E1ZX
O/o Chief Engineer (Store & Purchase) 3rd Floor, SLDC Building, Daganiya, Raipur(C.G.)-492013
No.02-16/SE/S&P/TR-25/S&P/51/55/1699 Raipur, Dtd.02.03.2026
E-BIDDING TENDER NOTICE
Online bids are invited by the undersigned through CSPTCL e-bidding system (SAP SRM) from experienced manufacturers/eligible bidders for Supply of following material-

S.N.	Tender no./Rfx No.	Description	Due Date & time
1.	TR- 25/S&P/51 RFX No-8100049642	63 MVA Power Transformer alongwith oil & accessories	30.03.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs
2.	TR-25/S&P/55 RFX No-8100049793	Mobile switchyard Equipment Testing Van with Integrated Testing Equipment	27.03.2026 Upto 15:00 Hrs

The details of NIT can be viewed from our website www.cspc.co.in and the Tender Documents can be viewed and downloaded online from our e-bidding portal:- <https://ebidding.cspcl.co.in:50724/irj/portal>
Any amendment/corrigendum, if required, will be displayed on our website only.
Chief Engineer (S&P)
CSPTCL : Raipur
“SAVE ELECTRICITY” samvad 47066/2

PHYSICAL POSSESSION NOTICE
ICICI Bank Branch office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005
The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.
Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Physical Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Dhirendra Verma / Snehlata Verma / LBDEL00002974099	Flat No. 801, 8th Floor, Block B, Type A, Inc Greenswoods, Situated At Plot No.3/ Gh, Sector-3, Vasundhara, Ghaziabad / February 26, 2026	May 24, 2018 Rs. 49,51,051/-	Delhi/ Ncr/ Sitapur Up
2.	Shubir Walter Abraham / Shumir Oliver Abraham/ Edna Abraham/ LBDEL00005394144 / LBDEL00005394146	Dda Flat No. 1136 3rd Floor With Scooter Garage Sfs- Cat II, Sector D Pocket 1, Vasant Kunj Delhi 110070 / February 26, 2026	October 10, 2025 Rs. 1,34,42,130.86/-	Delhi Ncr

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.
Date: March 03, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr
Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE
ICICI Bank Branch office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005
The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.
Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Anju Rani/ Ashok Kumar Verma/ LBROH00002510709	House Situated on Plot No 91 And 92, H No- 1950, New H No-1040/21, Prem, Nagar, Rohtak, Haryana- 124001/ February 25, 2026	October 09,2025 Rs. 4,67,174/-	Rohtak (Haryana)
2.	Kulvinder/ Priya/ TBROH000006283338 / TBROH000006752778	Ppid Bgr/A06/289, Part of Bearing Khewat No. 846/741, Khatoni No.1022, Kila No. 48/8/1 (5-9) Rakba 5 Kanal 9 Marla 100/3297 Part of Plot, Inside Mc Limit Bahadurgarh, Situated At Parnala Hari Nagar (Johari Nagar) Railway Line Par Tehsil Bahadurgarh District Jhajjar, District, Bahadurgarh- 124507/ February 25, 2026	October 30, 2025 Rs. 29,49,924/-	Bahadurgarh (Haryana)/ Delhi

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.
Date: March 03, 2026
Place: Bahadurgarh & Delhi
Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

RailMadad Helpline No. 139
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Serving customers with a smile

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE
ICICI Bank Branch Office: ICICI Bank Ltd., BP-4, Technopolis Building, 4th Floor, Sector V, Salt Lake City, Kolkata West Bengal- 700091
CIN No: L65190G1994PLC021012, www.icicibank.com
The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.
Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Sumit Roy Chowdhury/ Kalpana Roy Chowdhury/ 33/8B Ranipark Kamarhati Belgharia, P.O. And P.S. Belgharia, District North 24 Pgs West Bengal Kolkata - 700056/ LBAL00006593938/ LBAL00006602188	Shirram Grand City "Project Sunshine Two", Flat No. 2c-16-L, Tower- 2C, 16th Floor, L.R. Dag No 4473 & 4474(P), L.R. Khatian No 11976, Mouza Konnagar, J.L. No. 7, And L.R. Dag No. 1888(P), 1894(P), 1896(P), L.R. Khatian No. 1808, Dag No. 4474(P), Mouza Khordabahera, J.L. No. 6, Police Station Uttarpara, Kanaiapur Gram Panchayat, District Hooghly, Pin- 712246, West Bengal, Owned By Sumit Roy Chowdhury (Admeasuring An Area of Super Built Up Area 630 Sq. Ft, Built Up Area 464.4 Sq. Ft, Carpet Area -400.4 Sq. Ft, Exclusive Balcony 10.8 Sq. Ft. Along With One Designated Two Wheeler Parking Space Together With The Undivided Proportionate Right To Use Common Areas And Common Utilities North: By Others Land South: By 4474(P), 1902 East By Plot No. 4474(P) West: By Plot Nos. 1887(P), 1888(P), 1889(P), 1893(P), 1894(P), 1895(P), 1896(P)./ Date of Symbolic 26/02/2026	October 28,2025 Rs. 9,96,753.99/-	Hooghly Gurgoon

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.
Date: March 03, 2026
Place: Gurgaon
Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

कार्यालय, जिला परिषद, कोडरमा।
अति अत्यकालीन ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या — 04/ 2025—26 (Third Call)
वितीय वर्ष 2024—25 में पंचायती राज विभाग द्वारा जिला परिषद कोडरमा अंतर्गत विभिन्न नवनों, परिसरमितिओं का निर्माण, मरम्मत एवं नवीनीकरण मद्द से स्वीकृति प्रदत्त क्रमांक 01 में वर्णित कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। विवरणी निम्नवत् है:-

क्र० सं०	प्रखण्ड का नाम	कार्य का नाम	परिमाण विपत्र की राशि (रुपये में)	अग्रधन की राशि (रुपये में)	परिमाण विपत्र का मूल्य (रुपये में)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि
01	कोडरमा	Construction of Zila Parishad Koderma Office Building	80812524.00	1616500.00	10000.00	24 माह

1. वेबसाईट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि :- 07.03.2026
2. प्री बिड Meeting की तिथि एवं समय:- 10.03.2026 पूर्वा० 11.00 बजे।
3. ई-निविदा प्राप्ति की तिथि एवं समय :- 12.03.2026 से 21.03.2026 अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक।
4. निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय :- 23.03.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे।
5. निविदा आमंत्रित करने वाले पदाधिकारी का नाम एवं पता:- जिला अभियंता, जिला परिषद कोडरमा।
6. ई-निविदा प्रकोष्ठ का दूरभाष सं० 8002536460 एवं ई-मेल ddczpkoderma@gmail.com
7. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि केवल Online Mode द्वारा स्वीकार्य होगी।
8. निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रधन की राशि का ई-मुद्रातन जित खता से किया जायेगा, उसी खाते में अग्रधन की राशि वापस होगी। अगर खाता को बन्द कर दिया जाता है तो उसकी राशि जवाबदेही संबंधित निविदाता/संबंधक की होगी।
निविदा की शर्त कार्यालय के सूचना पट्ट पर या www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।
जिला अभियंता,
जिला परिषद, कोडरमा।
PR 374015 Panchayati Raj(25-26)D

UJJN LIMITED
(An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprise)
H.O. "UJJAWAL" MAHARANI BAGH, GMS ROAD, DEHRADUN - 248006, CN No. 040101UR2001SCC23866
Tels. 0135-2763508, 2763808, Fax: 0135-2763507, website: www.ujjnl.com
No. 183 Date: 02.03.2026
Time Extension Notice -I
Due to unavoidable reasons the schedule date of e- Tender No: 13/EE(Gen)/Khodri/2025-26: Annual Maintenance Contract for O&M works of Khodri Power Station" invited by office of Executive Engineer (Generation), Khodri Power Station, Dakpathar is extended as given below:-
Last date for submission of tender on portal: 07.03.2026 upto 16:00 hrs
Last date of submission of original documents in hard copy : 09.03.2026 upto 16:00 hrs.
Date of opening of tender on portal : 10.03.2026 at 12:30
All other terms & conditions of the tender shall remain unaltered.
Executive Engineer (Generation)
"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused 1) Sunil, S/o Lt. Sh. Bhoop Singh, R/o 17/17, Subhash Nagar, New Delhi, 2) Abdul Manan, S/o Ismail, R/o 14/76A, Back Side, Subhash Nagar, New Delhi has committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 584/2018, Dated 23.09.2018, U/s 279/337 IPC, P.S. Rajouri Garden, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said 1) Sunil, 2) Abdul Manan cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said 1) Sunil, 2) Abdul Manan has absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said 1) Sunil, 2) Abdul Manan accused of FIR No. 584/2018, Dated 23.09.2018, U/s 279/337 IPC, P.S. Rajouri Garden, New Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 14.04.2026.
By Order - Sh. Shashank Nandan Bhatt
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
DP/2514/WD/2026 West District, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Hussain Mohmad, S/o Isha Mohmad, R/o H. No. Jhuggi-7A, Seva Nagar, Railway Falak, Kotla Mubarakpur, New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. E-026906/2016, U/s 379 IPC, P.S. Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Hussain Mohmad cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Hussain Mohmad has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said Hussain Mohmad accused of FIR No. E-026906/2016, U/s 379 IPC, P.S. Sarojini Nagar, New Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 16.04.2026 at 10:00 AM.
By Order - Ms. Vijayshree Rathore
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Room No. 13, 1st Floor, Main Building
DP/1940/SW/2026 Patiala House Courts, New Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Rajesh Kumar Nayyar S/o Late Lal Chand R/o H 5/12, SF, Malviya Nagar, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CT Case No. 472072/2016 U/s 200 CR.PC, PS Malviya Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Rajesh Kumar Nayyar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rajesh Kumar Nayyar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Rajesh Kumar Nayyar** in **CT Case No. 472072/2016 U/s 200 CR.PC, PS Malviya Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **08.04.2026**.
By order
Shri Bhanu Pratap Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
Room No. 213
Saket Court Complex, New Delhi
DP/2713/SD/2026

Sensex & Nifty tumble over 1% as crisis in West Asia intensifies

The market capitalisation (mcap) of BSE-listed companies eroded by Rs 6,59,978.08 crore to Rs 4,56,90,693.19 crore (\$5 trillion)

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Stock market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty nosedived over 1 per cent on Monday as investors' sentiment were hit hard following a sharp spike in crude oil prices amid escalating tensions in West Asia.

Weak trends in global markets and heavy foreign fund outflows also dented sentiments.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 2,743.46 points or 3.37 per cent to 78,543.73 in early trade. It later ended at 80,238.85, down 1,048.34 points or 1.29 per cent.

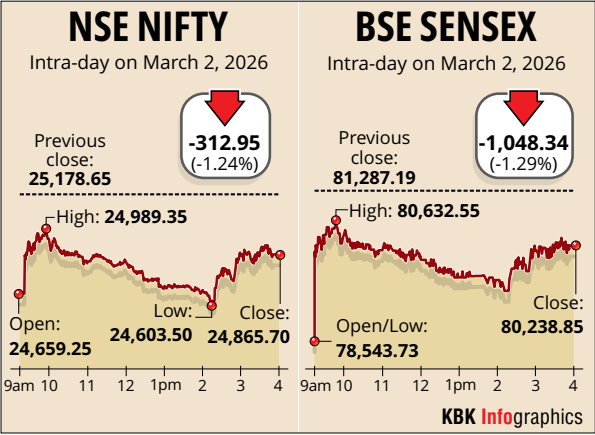
The 50-share NSE Nifty tumbled 575.15 points or 2.28 per cent to 24,603.50 in intra-day trade. The benchmark later settled 312.95 points or 1.24 per cent down at 24,865.70.

From the Sensex pack, InterGlobe Aviation, Larsen & Toubro, Adani Ports, Maruti, Asian Paints, and Bajaj Finserv were among the biggest laggards.

Bharat Electronics, Sun Pharma and ITC were the only gainers.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 8.34 per cent to \$78.95 per barrel.

"Indian equity markets closed with a bearish undertone



Among sectoral indices, services tumbled 3.81%, consumer durables (2.30%), auto (2.23%), consumer discretionary (2.16%), oil & gas (2.15%), industrials (2.14%) and energy (2.06%)

after opening sharply lower in response to the deepening military conflict across the Middle East, which pushed crude oil prices markedly higher," Ponnudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

The market capitalisation (mcap) of BSE-listed companies eroded by Rs 6,59,978.08 crore to Rs 4,56,90,693.19 crore

(\$5 trillion). The BSE smallcap select index tanked 1.81 per cent and midcap select index dropped 1.67 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, services tumbled 3.81 per cent, consumer durables (2.30 per cent), auto (2.23 per cent), consumer discretionary (2.16 per cent), oil & gas (2.15 per cent), industrials (2.14 per cent) and

Highlights

» From the Sensex pack, Larsen & Toubro, Adani Ports, Maruti, Asian Paints and Bajaj Finserv were among the biggest laggards

» Bharat Electronics, Sun Pharma and ITC were the only gainers

» The BSE smallcap select index tanked 1.81 per cent and midcap select index dropped 1.67 per cent

» A total of 3,561 stocks declined, while 821 advanced and 146 remained unchanged on the BSE

» Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 7,536.36 crore on Friday, according to exchange data.

Domestic Institutional Investors (DIIs), however, bought stocks worth Rs 12,292.81 crore.

Rupee falls 41 paise to 91.49 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee saw a steep loss of 41 paise to settle at 91.49 against the US dollar on Monday after US and Israeli attacks on Iran intensified worldwide risk aversion, setting crude oil prices on fire and demand for the American currency soaring.

Massive selling in domestic equity markets & foreign fund outflows further dragged the Indian currency down, forex traders said. At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 91.23 and touched the intraday low of 91.65 against the greenback.

The currency ended the session at 91.49 against the dollar, registering a steep loss of 41 paise from the previous closing level. Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading 0.67 per cent higher at 98.22.

CAD widens to \$13.2 billion in third quarter on higher trade deficit

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: India's current account deficit (CAD) rose to \$13.2 billion, or 1.3 per cent of GDP, in the December quarter from \$11.3 billion in the year-ago period, mainly due to a higher trade deficit caused by a decline in exports to the US, according to RBI data released on Monday.

However, the current account deficit moderated to \$30.1 billion (1 per cent of GDP) in April-December 2025, from \$36.6 billion (1.3 per cent of GDP) in the same period a year ago.

"India's current account deficit increased to \$13.2 billion (1.3 per cent of GDP) in Q3:2025-26 from \$11.3 billion (1.1 per cent of GDP) in Q3:2024-25," the RBI's data on Developments in India's Balance of Payments said.

Merchandise trade deficit at \$93.6 billion in the quarter was higher than \$79.3 billion in the same period a year ago.

Net services receipts increased to \$57.5 billion during the period from \$51.2 billion a year ago, the RBI said. Services exports have risen on an annual basis in major categories such as computer services and other business services.

It further said that net outgo on the primary income account, mainly reflecting payments of investment income, decreased to \$12.2 billion from \$16.4 billion in the third quarter of the previous financial year.

Personal transfer receipts under the secondary income



However, the current account deficit moderated to \$30.1 billion (1% of GDP) in April-December 2025

account, mainly representing remittances by Indians employed overseas, rose to \$36.9 billion from \$35.1 billion in the December quarter a year ago.

As regards foreign direct investment (FDI), it said, there was a net outflow of \$3.7 billion, higher than a net outflow of \$2.8 billion in the third quarter of the previous fiscal.

At the same time, Foreign portfolio investment (FPI) recorded a net outflow of \$0.2 billion as against net outflow of \$11.4 billion in Q3 of 2024-25.

However, Non-resident deposits (NRI deposits) recorded a net inflow of \$5.1 billion, higher than \$3.1 billion mobilised in the third quarter of 2024-25.

Net inflows under external commercial borrowings (ECBs) to India amounted to \$3.3 billion, lower than a net inflow of \$4.4 billion in the third quarter

of 2024-25. Foreign exchange reserves depleted by \$24.4 billion (on a BoP basis) in comparison to a depletion of \$37.7 billion in the same period a year ago.

For the nine months ending December 2025, net FDI inflows increased to \$3.0 billion from \$0.6 billion in April-December 2024. However, FPI recorded net outflows of \$4.3 billion as against net inflows of \$9.4 billion a year ago.

In April-December 2025, foreign exchange reserves depleted by \$30.8 billion (on a BoP basis) as compared to a depletion of \$13.8 billion a year ago.

Looking ahead, ICRA Chief Economist Aditi Nayar said, the unusually higher-than-expected merchandise trade deficit (MTD) for January 2026 is likely to limit the seasonal improvement in the current account balance in Q4 FY2026, unless the prints for February and March 2026 cool significantly.

Additionally, she said, the recent surge in international crude oil prices, following the escalation of conflict in West Asia, is also likely to have some bearing on the import bill in the immediate term.

"We currently expect the current account balance to print between -\$1.0 billion and +\$1 billion in Q4 FY2026. We estimate India's current account deficit to print at around 0.6-0.7 per cent of GDP in FY2026, and rise thereafter to around 1 per cent of GDP in FY2027, albeit with risks tilted to the upside," she said.

India's foreign exchange reserves rise \$19.4 billion in April-December 2025

MUMBAI: The country's foreign exchange reserves in nominal terms, including valuation effects, rose \$19.4 billion during April-December 2025, against a depletion of \$10.7 billion in April-December 2024, according to the Reserve Bank data.

On a balance of payments basis, excluding valuation effects, foreign exchange reserves decreased \$30.8 billion during April-December 2025, as compared to depletion of \$13.8 billion during April-December 2024.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Monday released Sources of Variation in Foreign Exchange Reserves in India during April-Decem-

ber 2025.

The valuation gain, primarily reflecting higher price of gold, depreciation of US dollar against major currencies and lower bond yields, increased to \$50.2 billion during April-December 2025 from \$3.1 billion during April-December 2024.

The current account balance recorded a deficit of \$30.2 billion during April-December 2025, as against a deficit of \$36.7 billion during April-December 2024.

During April-December 2025, there was a capital account deficit of \$0.6 billion, compared to a surplus of \$22.9 billion in a similar period last year, the data showed.

Sebi boosts tech-driven enforcement to curb investors scam & safeguard retail investors

MUMBAI: Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey on Monday said the regulator is stepping up surveillance and technology-driven enforcement to curb rising pre-investment scams targeting retail investors.

Marking one year in office on March 1, Pandey said many new and prospective investors are being lured through fake trading apps, WhatsApp groups and promises of assured high returns. In several cases, funds are diverted to fraudsters' personal accounts even before investors approach Sebi-registered intermediaries.

Describing such incidents as "quite many", he said Sebi is intensifying investor awareness drives and promoting tools like "SEBI Check" to help verify legitimate entities and



Sebi Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey

payment handles. Multimedia and multilingual campaigns are being rolled out to widen outreach. He also urged investors to adopt disciplined, long-term strategies such as SIPs and avoid speculative trading in complex derivatives without adequate understanding, cautioning against unregistered "influencers" promising unre-

'Many new investors are being lured through fake trading apps, WhatsApp groups and promises of assured high returns'

alistic gains.

On the technology front, Pandey highlighted Sebi's growing use of AI and data analytics to track market misconduct, misleading content and unregistered advisory activities in real time. India currently has over 140 million unique investors.

Addressing governance issues, he said recommenda-

tions of the high-level committee on conflict of interest—set up in March 2025—were discussed by the board and will undergo further deliberation.

On recent glitches at Multi Commodity Exchange of India (MCX) and National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL), Pandey said Sebi monitored developments closely.

Operations were shifted to disaster recovery sites where required, and root cause analyses will be reviewed by the Technical Advisory Committee before remedial steps are implemented.

He added that Sebi is also reviewing aspects of Portfolio Management Services regulations, including easing portability for investors shifting between portfolio managers.

RBI: 98.44% of withdrawn ₹2K banknotes returned

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Monday said 98.44 per cent of the Rs 2,000 banknotes in circulation have been returned.

The total value of Rs 2,000 banknotes in circulation has declined to Rs 5,551 crore at the close of business on February 28, 2026, from Rs 3.56 lakh crore at the close of business on May 19, 2023, when the central bank announced withdrawal of Rs 2000 banknotes, the release said.

A facility for exchanging Rs 2000 banknotes is available at the 19 issue offices of

the Reserve Bank (RBI Issue Offices) since May 19, 2023. From October 9, 2023, RBI issue offices also accept Rs 2,000 banknotes from individuals/entities for deposit into their bank accounts.

Additionally, members of the public are sending Rs 2,000 banknotes through India Post from any post office within the country to any of the RBI issue offices for credit to their bank accounts, the RBI said in a release.

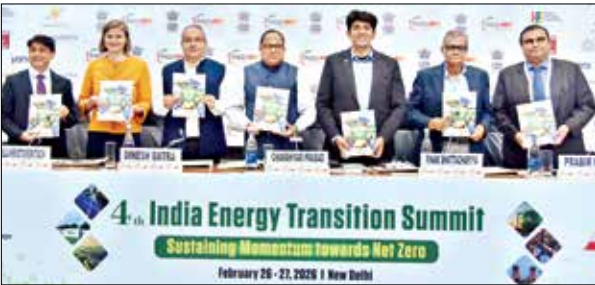
The central bank further said Rs 2,000 banknotes continue to be legal tender.

'India's energy transition firmly underway, driven by clear targets & decisive policy action'

NEW DELHI: Shripad Yesso Naik, Minister of State for Power and New & Renewable Energy, Govt of India on Monday said India's energy transition is firmly underway, driven by clear targets and decisive policy action.

Addressing the two-day India Energy Transition Summit organised by FICCI, he reiterated the government's goal of achieving 500 GW of non-fossil fuel capacity by 2030 and net zero emissions by 2070 under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision.

Naik said India's installed power capacity has crossed 520 GW, with over half from non-fossil sources. Solar capacity has more than tripled in recent



years, supported by transparent bidding, green energy corridors, ultra-mega renewable parks, rooftop solar under PM Surya Ghar Yojana and agricultural solarisation through PM KUSUM.

He added that the National Green Hydrogen Mission will drive industrial decarboni-

sation and reduce import dependence.

Emphasising the need to move beyond capacity addition, Naik called for stronger transmission networks, storage expansion, grid flexibility and financially sound distribution companies, while ensuring energy security and

affordability.

Ghanshyam Prasad, Chairperson, Central Electricity Authority, said India now has a long-term roadmap up to 2070, focusing on resource adequacy, electrification, storage and transmission planning.

The next phase will require balancing renewable growth with grid stability and market reforms.

Industry leaders highlighted the importance of coordinated action among policymakers, financiers and developers to accelerate progress.

A FICCI-CRISIL report on energy storage and a souvenir on India's energy transition were released at the inaugural session.

State Bank of India relieves Nitin Chugh as DMD & Head Digital Banking

MUMBAI: State Bank of India (SBI) on Monday announced that Nitin Chugh has been relieved from his role as Deputy Managing Director and Head (Digital Banking & Transformation), effective March 2, 2026.

In a regulatory filing under Regulation 30 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the bank said Chugh's contractual tenure was scheduled to conclude on March 3, 2026.

However, since March 3 is a public holiday, he was relieved at the close of business on March 2.



The disclosure was submitted to BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited, where State Bank of India's shares are listed.

The bank stated that his exit follows the completion of his contractual term. No successor has been announced so far.

FICCI CASCADE holds workshop for police to curb illicit trade

The programme brought together officers of ACP rank and above from Delhi, along with industry representatives

NEW DELHI: FICCI's Committee Against Smuggling and Counterfeiting Activities Destroying the Economy (CASCADe) organised a training workshop for police officers on "Strengthening Enforcement against Illicit Trade and Economic Offences" at the Academy for Smart Policing in Chanakyapuri.

The programme brought together ACP-rank and above officers from Delhi and industry representatives to deliberate on the growing menace of counterfeiting and smuggling, which impact economic growth, distort markets and pose risks



to public safety. Deep Chand, Advisor, FICCI CASCADE and former Special Commissioner of

Police, New Delhi, said illicit trade causes heavy losses to legitimate businesses, erodes consumer trust and reduces

CLOSER LOOK

» 'Illicit trade causes heavy losses to legitimate businesses, erodes consumer trust & reduces govt revenues'

» Representatives from leading firms, including Amazon and Hindustan Unilever Ltd., highlighted emerging digital risks

government revenues. He also warned of serious health and safety risks from unregulated products.

An interactive session focused on industry concerns and closer coordination with enforcement agencies. ITC Ltd. Vice President (Corporate Affairs) Ashish Paul said curbing illicit trade by even 50 per cent could unlock growth, generate jobs and strengthen India's self-reliance goals.

Representatives from leading firms, including Amazon and Hindustan Unilever Ltd., highlighted emerging digital risks and the need for collaborative enforcement. Amazon reiterated its commitment to maintaining a trusted online marketplace.

According to a FICCI CASCADE report, the illicit market across five key sectors — FMCG packaged goods, personal and household care, alcohol, tobacco, and textiles and apparel — is estimated at about Rs 7.97 lakh crore, with textiles and apparel accounting for over half. The study noted that illicit trade significantly undermines businesses and government revenues, particularly in highly taxed sectors such as tobacco and alcohol. FICCI CASCADE continues to work with enforcement agencies & stakeholders to combat counterfeiting and smuggling.



The Prime Ministers Museum and Library (PMML) Located at Teen Murti Bhawan in New Delhi, celebrated National Science Day as 'Vigyan Utsav' on Saturday, hosting a day-long series of activities. On the same occasion, the museum also commemorated the 130th birth anniversary of former Prime Minister Morarji Desai. Ashwani Lohani Director, PMML inaugurated the event in presence of Dr. Priyanka Mishra, CEO, Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya

No petrol, diesel price hike despite global oil prices spiking to \$80

Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri reviewed situation on crude oil, LPG & other petro products with senior officials & public sector companies

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: International oil prices rose about 9 per cent following US and Israeli attacks on Iran and retaliatory strikes by Tehran, but retail petrol and diesel prices in India are unlikely to be increased in the near term, sources said.

Brent crude, the global benchmark, climbed close to \$80 per barrel, while US-traded crude rose 8.6 per cent to \$72.79, up from around \$67 on Friday.

For India, which imports 88 per cent of its requirement of crude oil, which is turned into fuels like petrol and diesel at refineries, higher global prices translate into a larger import bill and potential inflationary pressures.

However, retail fuel prices are not expected to be raised immediately, as the government continues to follow a calibrated policy of allowing companies to build margins when international prices are low and cushioning consumers when rates rise, sources said.

Retail petrol and diesel prices have been on a freeze since April 2022, with fuel retailers like Indian Oil, BPCL and HPCL absorbing losses when crude prices are high



The government wants to continue to shield consumers and the same policy will continue unless there is a huge spike in crude prices

and making profits when rates are low.

This meant that when globally fuel prices went up in response to elevated crude prices, prices were stable in India. And when softening of crude prices pushed down fuel rates globally, rates in India remained unchanged.

The government wants to continue to shield consumers and the same policy will continue unless there is a huge spike in crude prices, they said.

With assembly elections in critical states like West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, and Assam round

Key Points

» Retail petrol and diesel prices have been on a freeze since April 2022, with fuel retailers like Indian Oil, BPCL and HPCL absorbing losses

» India imports 88% of its crude oil needs and roughly half of its natural gas requirement

» These mostly come via the Strait of Hormuz, which the Iranian authorities have threatened to shut down

the corner, it doesn't want anything that could give the opposition a handle.

As military conflict in the Middle East escalated, Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Monday reviewed the situation on crude oil, LPG and other petroleum products with senior officials from his ministry and public sector companies.

India imports 88 per cent of its crude oil needs and roughly half of its natural gas requirement. These mostly come via the Strait of Hormuz, which the Iranian authorities have threatened to shut down following

attacks by the US and Israel.

"We are continuously monitoring the evolving situation and all steps will be taken in order to ensure availability and affordability of major petroleum products in the country," the ministry said in a post on X.

Following the US and Israeli attacks on Iranian government, military and nuclear facilities, Iran warned shipping away from the strait and insurers withdrew coverage, effectively halting tanker movements.

"They (oil companies) have enough cushion to sustain this kind of prices spike," a source with direct knowledge of the matter said. "We have seen prices rise to \$119 per barrel in June 2022 in the aftermath of the Russia's invasion of Ukraine. That year they had nominal profits but in FY24 they posted record Rs 81,000 crore profit." This year, the three companies have posted Rs 23,743 crore profit in the December quarter alone.

Crisil Intelligence Director Sehul Bhatt said developments in the Middle East could increase pricing and procurement risks for crude oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG), posing substantial challenges for India. India meets roughly half of its gas supply through

imports.

"If geopolitical issues ease, we expect prices to average \$65-70 in CY2026, but prolonged conflict could push prices even higher," Bhatt said. "While Iran supplies 4.5-5 per cent of global oil, the main concern is disruption at the Strait of Hormuz which is vital for almost half of India's imports of both these commodities, thus increasing vulnerability."

If disruptions persist, shipments may be rerouted via the Cape of Good Hope, lengthening transit times and increasing the cost along with rising freight and insurance premiums.

"Sustained disruptions would keep crude prices elevated and tighten LNG availability underscoring the need for strategic planning to protect India's energy security," Bhatt said.

The US and Israel launched military strikes on targets in Iran over the weekend. Tehran retaliated with missiles and drones aimed at Israel and countries hosting US forces, including the UAE, Qatar, Kuwait, Bahrain, Iraq, Jordan, and Saudi Arabia.

Media reports suggest the conflict has effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz, a key conduit for global energy flows.

India and Canada launch talks for free trade agreement

The CEPA and the negotiations would cover trade in goods, services and other mutually agreed policy areas

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and Canada have launched negotiations for a free trade agreement and look to finalise the pact soon, an official statement said on Monday.

The pact is officially known as the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) and the negotiations would cover trade in goods, services and other mutually agreed policy areas. The Terms of Reference (ToR) for the agreement were signed by Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and his Canadian counterpart Maninder Sidhu.

It was exchanged in the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Prime Minister Mark Carney of Canada at Hyderabad House here.

"India and Canada launched negotiations for the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) today in New Delhi and decided to finalise it soon," the commerce ministry said.

The ToR of negotiations will provide format, frequency, and approach to the CEPA negotiations. It will serve as a guide to facilitate negotiations in order to conclude an ambitious, balanced and mutually beneficial pact. The launch marks the resumption of negotiations, as the two countries had earlier engaged in a similar exercise,



Prime Minister Narendra Modi & Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney witness an MoU exchange between Union Minister of Commerce & Industry Piyush Goyal and Canada Minister of International Trade Maninder Sidhu during a joint press meet, at Hyderabad House in New Delhi on Monday

but Canada paused it in 2023. Now they decided to resume talks from the beginning as a lot has changed on the global trade front during these two years.

The negotiations are important as the two sides have fixed a target to increase the bilateral trade to \$50 billion by 2030. At present, it stood at \$8.66 billion in 2024-25 (\$4.22 billion exports and \$4.44 billion imports). Canada represents a market of 41.65 million people (2025) and a GDP of \$2.34 trillion at purchasing power parity.

Key exports from India to Canada include pharmaceuticals, iron and steel, seafood, cotton garments, electronic goods and chemicals, among

others. Key imports include pulses, pearls and semi-precious stones, coal, fertiliser, paper and petroleum crude. India's main services sector exports include telecommunications, computer and information services, and other business services.

"These sectors hold significant future growth potential and are expected to expand further following the conclusion of the CEPA," it said.

Canada is also home to over 425,000 Indian students and a strong Indian community. Joint Secretary in the Department of Commerce, Brij Mohan Mishra, is the chief negotiator from the Indian side. Bruce Christie is Canada's chief negotiator.

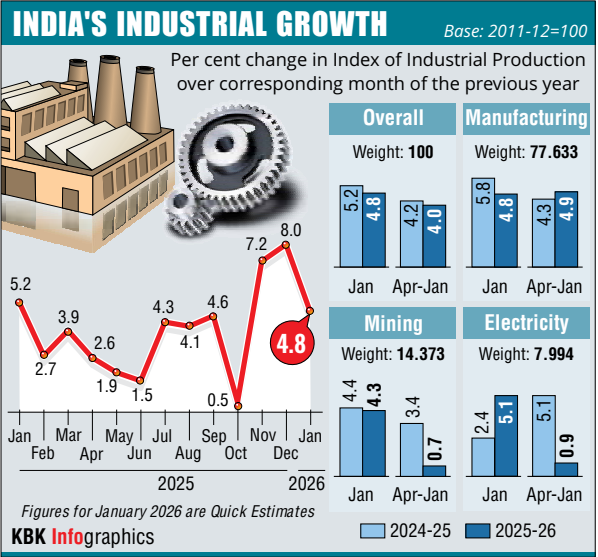
IIP declines to 3-month low of 4.8% in Jan

NEW DELHI: India's industrial production growth decelerated to a three-month low of 4.8 per cent in January, pulled down by subdued performance in the manufacturing and mining sectors, according to official data released on Monday.

The factory output, measured in terms of the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), expanded by 5.2 per cent in January 2025. The previous low was witnessed in October 2025 at 0.5 per cent. The IIP growth was 7.2 per cent in November 2025, an official statement said.

The National Statistics Office (NSO) revised the industrial production growth for December 2025 to 8 per cent from the provisional estimate of 7.8 per cent released in January 2026.

The NSO data further showed that the manufacturing sector's output growth decelerated to 4.8 per cent in January 2025, compared to 5.8 per cent



in the year-ago month.

Mining production growth also slowed marginally to 4.3 per cent compared to a growth of 4.4 per cent recorded a year

ago. Power generation grew by 5.1 per cent in January 2025, compared to 2.4 per cent expansion in the year-ago period.

During the April-January

period of FY26, the country's industrial production growth also slowed slightly to 4 per cent, compared to 4.2 per cent in the same period a year ago.

The corresponding growth rates of IIP as per use-based classification in January 2026 over January 2025 are 3.1 per cent in primary goods, 4.3 per cent in capital goods, 6.0 per cent in intermediate goods, 13.7 per cent in infrastructure/ construction goods, 6.3 per cent in consumer durables and (-) 2.7 per cent in consumer non-durables. Based on use-based classification, top three positive contributors to the growth of IIP for the month of January 2026 are infrastructure/ construction goods, intermediate goods and primary goods.

Within the manufacturing sector, 14 out of 23 industry groups have recorded a positive growth in January 2026 over January 2025.

India's manufacturing sector activity growth rises to four-month high in February: PMI

NEW DELHI: India's manufacturing sector activity growth jumped to a four-month high of 56.9 in February, supported by substantial improvement in domestic demand even as growth in new export orders witnessed a decline, a monthly survey said on Monday.

The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) rose from 55.4 in January to a four-month high of 56.9 in February.

In the PMI parlance, a print above 50 means expansion, while a score below 50 denotes contraction. "India's final manufacturing PMI reflected an acceleration in manufacturing activity in February. Output expanded at a faster rate for a second month, supported by stronger domestic orders,"

Pranjul Bhandari, Chief India Economist at HSBC, said.

Goods producers indicated that demand buoyancy, marketing initiatives and rising client requirements underpinned another expansion in new business intakes.

"According to panel members, efficiency improvements, healthy underlying demand, rising intakes of new work and tech investment collectively boosted production volumes," the survey said.

One area where growth took a step back was new export orders. Where external sales rose, monitored companies cited gains from Asia,

Europe the Middle East and the US. "Growth in new export orders continued its slowing trend that began in mid-2025, somewhat restricting employment creation in the manufacturing sector," Bhandari said.

On the price front, cost pressures remained benign, rising at a moderate rate that matched the level seen in January.

With total new orders continuing to expand sharply, manufacturers in India purchased additional materials to supplement production and add to inventories.

In response to increasing workloads, firms stepped up

input purchasing, lifted their inventories and hired extra staff.

Meanwhile, year-ahead assessments of output volumes remained positive as 16 per cent of companies forecast growth and fewer than 1 per cent anticipate a reduction.

Boding well to the outlook were marketing efforts and favourable demand conditions, the qualitative survey data showed.

The HSBC India Manufacturing PMI is compiled by S&P Global from responses to questionnaires sent to purchasing managers in a panel of around 400 manufacturers.

Govt buys back ₹13,788 crore G-sec in RBI's switch auction

MUMBAI: The government bought back government securities worth Rs 13,787.70 crore in a switch auction conducted by the RBI, while issuing fresh bonds worth Rs 13,646.89 crore, an official release said.

The repurchased securities were bonds maturing in the next financial year, including multiple tranches of 2026 and 2027 maturities. In return, the government issued longer-dated securities maturing between 2032 and 2039. This is the third switch auction announced by the RBI this month.

Through such operations, the government replaces near-term maturing bonds with long-term instruments to better manage its debt profile.

The move is aimed at easing redemption pressure in FY27, when bond maturities worth Rs 5.47 lakh crore fall due. With gross market borrowing for FY27 budgeted at Rs 17.2 lakh crore, the switch helps smoothen the maturity schedule and manage repayments more efficiently.

The Centre has pegged net market borrowing for FY27 at Rs 11.7 lakh crore, about Rs 50,000 crore higher than FY26, largely due to elevated maturities. AGENCIES

Reliance, Adani, Google & Lightspeed among top investors that pledge \$240 bn during AI Summit

NEW DELHI: Reliance Industries, Adani, Google, Lightspeed Ventures and Tata are among the top investors that cumulatively made commitment of \$240 billion investment in India during the India AI Impact Summit 2026, an official statement said on Monday.

The number released by the government shows that the India AI Impact Summit 2026, held from Feb 16-21, was the biggest AI event held till date, with approximately 6 lakh attendees in person, delegations from more than 100 countries and 20 international organisations participated in the proceedings.

Over \$200 billion in



AI-related investments are expected across infrastructure, foundation models, hardware and applications.

The India AI Impact Summit Declaration was endorsed by 92 countries and international organisations.

The New Delhi Frontier AI Impact Commitments were announced by 13 lead-

ing global and Indian frontier model developers to promote trustworthy and inclusive AI deployment.

According to the statement, Reliance Industries pledged \$110 billion over seven years towards AI-focused infrastructure, Adani Enterprises announced plans to invest \$100 billion by 2035, General Catalyst announced a \$5 billion investment commitment over five years, while Lightspeed Venture Partners announced \$10 billion in investments.

Google CEO Sundar Pichai announced investments including new India-US subsea cable routes and a \$15 billion AI hub in Visakhapatnam.

Meanwhile, Tata Group announced a partnership with OpenAI to scale AI-ready data centres.

A key announcement at the Summit was the expansion of India's sovereign compute capacity.

In addition to the over 38,000 GPUs already provisioned under the IndiaAI Mission, an additional 20,000 GPUs will be added in the coming weeks, further strengthening national AI infrastructure, the statement said.

The statement said that The AI Impact Expo emerged as one of the largest AI exhibitions globally, with over 850 exhibitors across 10 thematic pavilions.

Sunil Bharti Mittal shares succession plan

Bharti Telecom currently holds around 41 per cent stake in Airtel

NEW DELHI: Sunil Bharti Mittal has outlined a succession roadmap that will see the next generation of his family take on a larger ownership role in Bharti Telecom, the promoter of Bharti Airtel. Speaking at an investor call on February 26, Mittal said his children are independently running businesses and gaining experience outside Airtel.

"In a few years' time, you will start to see them at the shareholders' table more visible," he said, adding that he still has "some years" left to contribute to Airtel and Bharti Enterprises. Mittal's three children — Shravin Mittal, Kavin Mit-

CLOSER LOOK

» Mittal's three children — Shravin Mittal, Kavin Mittal and Eiesha Pasricha — are building their own ventures

» Shravin previously worked in operations at Airtel Africa after its acquisition in 2010 and has been on the board of Airtel Africa since 2018

tal and Eiesha Pasricha — are building their own ventures. Shravin previously worked in operations at Airtel Africa after its acquisition in 2010 and has been on the board of Airtel Africa since 2018.

Bharti Telecom currently holds around 41 per cent in Airtel. Mittal said he would like to

see the promoter entity raise its stake to over 50 per cent over time, potentially through large dividends or share buybacks.

However, he noted that a 40 per cent-plus holding in a Nifty-10 company remains a comfortable level for a promoter.

He expressed confidence in Airtel Africa's prospects, saying

it is poised to become a \$10 billion revenue company generating over \$5 billion in the coming years. The Africa business had supported the group during the challenging 2016-19 period for India's telecom sector.

On tariffs, Mittal reiterated that average revenue per user (ARPU) should rise to reflect inflation and service quality. While Airtel's ARPU stood at Rs 259 in Q3 2025, up from Rs 245 a year earlier, he suggested that an ARPU of around Rs 350 would be more appropriate in today's context. Analysts expect a possible 15 per cent tariff hike by mid-year.

MANIPUR STATE POWER DISTRIBUTION COMPANY LIMITED
(Regd. Office: Secure Office Complex, 3rd Floor, North AOC, A. T. Line, Imphal West, Manipur — 795001)
NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Imphal, the 26th Feb, 2026

No.2/102(DW-CAU-LT_AB)/2025-MSPDCL-TECH/260226/18-25: Manipur State Power Distribution Company Limited (MSPDCL) a Government of Manipur enterprise invites Sealed Tender from electrical license contractor/Firms for the below work:
TS No. 95/2/2025 - "Supply, Erection & Stringing of LT line (2.8 km) using LT AB Cable (3x50+1x25) Sq.mmm. for replacement of Old naked AAC Conductor inside the campus of CAU, Iratishemba"
The tender details and documents shall be available from 27/02/2026 to 12/03/2026 on payment of cost of tender of Rs. 500/- (non-refundable) at the office of the **General Manager (Purchase), MSPDCL, Secure Office Complex, 3rd Floor, North AOC, Imphal-West.**
Last date of Submission of Tender: 13/03/2026 (upto 11.00 A.M)
Date of Opening: 13/03/2026 (Time: 2.00 P.M.)
Venue: MSPDCL Conference Hall

Sd/-
(I. Saratchandra Singh)
General Manager (Purchase), MSPDCL

6/24/2024 DIPR (P-1)

कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता, अनुक्षणा खण्ड, उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान,
60/1, एक्का हाऊस, इन्दिरा नगर (अनुराग चौक के पास), देहरादून - 248006.
Phone No/Fax: 0135 2532509 Email Id: eemdujs@rediffmail.com

पत्रांक : 4647/ निविदा सूचना / 2025-26, दिनांक : 28.02.26
"जल संचय" जीवन संचय "

ई-निविदा सूचना
मुख्य महाप्रबन्धक, उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान, देहरादून की ओर से जलकल ऋषिकेश के अन्तर्गत यात्रा ट्रांजिट कैम्प परिसर में पम्प हाऊस निर्माण, चारधाम यात्रा मार्ग स्थित 02 नग उर्ध्व जलशय्य मरम्मत एवं तत्सम्बन्धित कार्य तथा चारधाम यात्रा 2026 की अवधि में यात्रियों को पेयजल उपलब्ध कराये जाने हेतु पेयजल व्यवस्था संबंधी कार्य हेतु ई-निविदा, सिंगल-बिड के आधार पर निम्नानुसार आमंत्रित की जाती है।

निविदा क्र.सं.	कार्य विवरण	धरोहर धनराशि (रु०में)	निविदा का मूल्य (रु०में)
1	2	3	4
1	जलकल ऋषिकेश के अन्तर्गत यात्रा ट्रांजिट कैम्प परिसर में पम्प हाऊस निर्माण, चारधाम यात्रा मार्ग स्थित 02 नग उर्ध्व जलशय्य मरम्मत एवं तत्सम्बन्धित कार्य तथा चारधाम यात्रा 2026 की अवधि में यात्रियों को पेयजल उपलब्ध कराये जाने हेतु पेयजल व्यवस्था संबंधी कार्य।	102350.00	4000+18% GST

निविदा समय सारणी (मुख्य तिथियाँ) निम्नवत् है।

क्र.सं०	विवरण	अनुसूची
1	ऑनलाइन प्रकाशन की तिथि।	05.03.2026 at 02:00 Hrs
2	निविदा प्रपत्र डाउनलोड करने की तिथि।	05.03.2026 at 02:00 Hrs
3	प्री-बिड मीटिंग की तिथि।	11.03.2026 at 11:00 Hrs
4	बिड ऑनलाइन जमा करने की प्रारम्भ तिथि।	05.03.2026 at 02:00 Hrs
5	बिड ऑनलाइन जमा करने की अन्तिम तिथि।	18.03.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs
6	ऑफ लाइन रूप से जमा किये जाने वाले प्रपत्र (निविदा प्रपत्र हेतु निर्धारित शुल्क, बिड सिक्वेरिट्री, स्टाम्प पेपर एवं अन्य सम्बन्धित दस्तावेज।	18.03.2026 upto 17:00 Hrs
7	बिड खोलने की तिथि।	20.03.2026 at 11:00 Hrs

ई-निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त जानकारीयों व शर्तें उत्तराखण्ड राज्य की वेबसाइट www.uktenders.gov.in पर ऑन लाइन देखी/ग्राप की जा सकती है।

अधिशासी अभियन्ता

GULAL & GROOVES

5 songs that make Holi special!

This Holi, let's rewind and groove to these festive favourites as we splash colours

OUR CORRESPONDENT

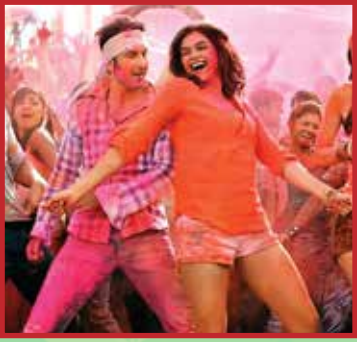
Can you imagine a Holi celebration without dancing to your favourite Bollywood playlist? This Holi, let's rewind and groove to these festive favourites as we splash colours.

RANG BARSE (SILSILA)



Nothing can beat this song from 'Silsila', sung by Amitabh Bachchan and composed by Shiv-Hari. With Amitabh Bachchan and Rekha dancing to lyrics penned by Harivansh Rai Bachchan, this remains an eternal favourite. Even if you don't know any other Holi song, you would definitely know this one.

BALAM PICHKARI (YEH JAWAANI HAI DEEWANI)



Pritam's composition, 'Balam Pichkari', perfectly blends youthful energy with desi elements. This song from the Ranbir Kapoor and Deepika Padukone-starrer 'Yeh Jawaani Hai Deewani' is a massive hit among youngsters. If you are at any Holi party, you can be sure this song will be on the playlist.

HOLI KE DIN DIL MIL JAATE HAIN (SHOLAY)

Just like 'Sholay' can never go out of style, neither can the songs from this cult classic. This RD Burman-composed gem, sung by Kishore Kumar and Lata Mangeshkar, highlights how Holi is a festival of unity.

DO ME A FAVOUR, LET'S PLAY HOLI (WAQT)

Not many may remember this 2005 Amitabh Bachchan and Akshay Kumar's father-son drama and Anu Malik's composition has certainly

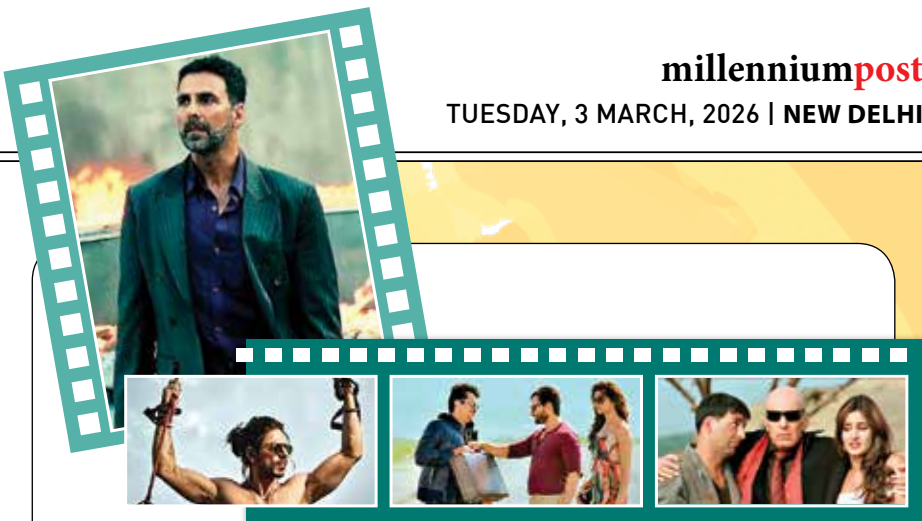
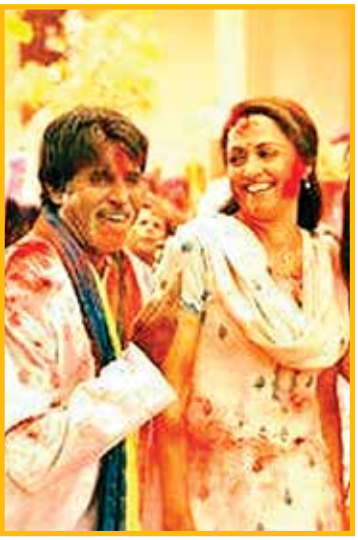


stayed popular with Gen Z. Featuring Akshay Kumar and Priyanka Chopra, the song is peppy and perfectly blends fun with flirtation. We might love its club-style vibe. Do you?

HOLI KHELE RAGHU-VEERA (BAGHBAN)

Amitabh Bachchan surely has some of the best Holi songs to his credit, like this soulful composition from

'Baghban'. Along with Udit Narayan's smooth vocals, the song features Bachchan's poetry, making it an absolute Holi favourite.



US-IRAN CONFLICT

BOLLYWOOD'S MIDDLE EAST connection in uncertain times

As tourists remain stranded and airspace shut amid the US-Iran conflict, the cinematic playground of the Gulf faces an unsettling new chapter

OUR CORRESPONDENT

For years, the Middle East, especially the UAE, has been Bollywood's favourite destination to shoot overseas. From glossy heist dramas to patriotic thrillers, its skyscrapers, deserts and luxury hotels have doubled as spectacle-filled cinematic canvases. Today, as parts of the region grapple with escalating war tensions amid the US-Iran conflict with flights cancelled, tourists stranded, as Iran's retaliatory strike continues in Qatar, UAE and Kuwait, these familiar film backdrops feel strikingly different. Here's a look at some major Bollywood films that brought the Middle East alive on screen:

Happy New Year: Shot extensively in Dubai, including the iconic Atlantis, The Palm, this Shah Rukh Khan-starrer revolved around a dance competition and a diamond heist. The UAE's luxury landscape wasn't just a backdrop; it was central to the story's spectacle and scale in this Farah Khan directorial. In



fact, the premiere of the 2014 film was held in Dubai.

Welcome: For anyone who loves a good comedy, this film starring Anil Kapoor, Nana Patekar and Akshay Kumar has to be an absolute favourite. This madcap comedy used Dubai's lavish hotels and skyline to amplify its larger-than-life humour. The city's glitz became synonymous with the film's flamboyant gangsters and extravagant lifestyle.

Bang Bang! Hrithik Roshan and Katrina Kaif's action thriller turned Abu Dhabi and Dubai into a playground for high-octane chases. From desert sequences to sleek city highways, the

Middle East added slick international flair.

Airlift: Perhaps the most politically rooted of the lot, 'Airlift' recreated 1990 Kuwait during the Gulf War. Though based on Iraq's invasion of Kuwait, much of it was shot in Ras Al Khaimah and other UAE locations. Ironically, a 2016 film starring Akshay Kumar and Nimrat Kaur about evacuation during war now resonates anew amid fresh regional tensions.

Race 2: Stylish, sleek and packed with twists, 'Race 2' showcased Abu Dhabi's Yas Marina Circuit and luxury resorts. The film leaned heavily into the Middle East's opulent modern identity.

Pathaan: The spy thriller starring Shah Rukh Khan featured portions shot in the UAE, using desert expanses and urban architecture to heighten its global espionage narrative. In fact, Shah Rukh Khan is a favourite in the Middle East with his films like 'Dunki', 'Zero' and 'Raaes' being shot in this portion of the world.

Jagdeep Dhankhar launches Yakub Mathew's 'Seeking the Infinite'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

On March 1, former Vice President Jagdeep Dhankhar launched 'Seeking the Infinite', a book authored by Yakub Mathew, Managing Director at 'Wells Fargo Advisors', New York.

Speaking at the event, Dhankhar described the book as 'deeply reflective and visually captivating', noting that it chronicles a once-in-a-lifetime spiritual journey undertaken by Mathew and his wife, Shilpa, during the Maha Kumbh Mela - a rare religious congregation held once every 144 years.

Several prominent personalities, including former Delhi University Vice-Chancellor Dinesh Singh, former Deputy Chief of Army Staff Philip Cam-



pose, BJP leader Sudhanshu Mittal, communications strategist Dilip Cherian and others attended the function.

More than a travelogue, the book weaves together personal insights, spiritual reflections and philosophical inquiry. It combines vivid photographs, intimate narratives and perspectives from fellow trav-

ellers, capturing the sacred atmosphere of the Kumbh and its emotional and metaphysical resonance.

As the journey unfolds, the narrative explores enduring questions about identity, consciousness and the purpose of existence. Drawing on contributions from over 50 global thought leaders, including spiritual masters, artists, political figures, entrepreneurs and scholars, the book presents diverse reflections on the idea of the Infinite and the unifying power of the Kumbh Mela.

'Seeking the Infinite' underscores themes of shared faith, collective humanity and India's enduring spiritual legacy, inviting readers to view life itself as an inward pilgrimage toward peace, truth and transcendence.

The Sassy Songbirds bedazzle with their harmonies!

JAI TALWAR

Goa has contributed immensely to Indian jazz music. Thanks to centuries of Portuguese influence and strong exposure to Western music through church traditions, their musicians were among the first Indians to master Western instruments, especially jazz. Many moved to Mumbai, Kolkata and Delhi to make their musical careers and from the fifties onwards, they contributed to introducing swing jazz instrumentation to many popular Bollywood songs in Mumbai.

Being a great fan of 'Manhattan Transfer', a multi award winning American vocal group famous for their intricate harmonies, this reviewer wondered if there was any vocal group in Mumbai that did covers of this group and was told by Vasund-



hara Vee, a leading jazz and soul singer from Mumbai a few years ago that there is a group called 'The Sassy Songbirds' in the city that does them proud. The trio comprises Marie Paul, Ella Castellino Atai and Mimosa Almeida Pinto, who not only doubles up on piano and keyboards but is also the composer and arranger behind their scintillating harmonies.

In an evening titled 'Har-

monious Jazz' at the Experimental Theatre at NCPA, Mumbai, last Saturday, 'The Sassy Songbirds' enthralled the sold-out concert with their repertoire of songs mostly from the 'Great American Songbook'. They were ably accompanied

by Russell Fernandes on bass and Adrian D'Souza on drums. Vir Bedi Kaushal accompanied them melodiously on the saxophone in some songs. Apart from the excellent harmonies, all three were very adept at jazz scatting, which stood out in songs such as 'One Note Samba' and 'Scat Awhile', the latter superbly composed and arranged by Mimosa. Other memorable songs were 'New York' and Duke Ellington's 'Don't Get Around Much Anymore', which had Ella and Marie at their best. The up-tempo version of Gershwin's

classic 'Summertime' was commendable. Other songs that had excellent harmonies were in Jamiroquai's 'Virtual Insanity' that blended into 'Autumn Leaves' as well as in 'Boy from Ipanema' and 'Caravan'. The evening's surprise guest, Dr Vernon Sequeira, offered a deep and soulful interpretation of 'Moon River' and joined the trio on some songs in the latter half of the concert. His presence added warmth and texture and one could easily imagine him contributing effectively to a future tribute to 'The Manhattan Transfer'.

The group concluded with 'Fly Me to the Moon' and returned for an encore of 'Life is Good', ending an evening that reaffirmed their place as one of Mumbai's most accomplished contemporary vocal jazz ensembles.

'SINNERS' takes top prize at the Actor Awards

Filmmaker Ryan Coogler's film has set up a potential nail-biter finale in two weeks at the Academy Awards

After a near awards-season sweep by 'One Battle After Another', 'Sinners' won best ensemble at the Screen Actors Guild's 32nd Actor Awards, shaking up the Oscar race and setting up a potential nail-biter finale in two weeks at the Academy Awards.

The guild's awards, formerly known as the SAG Awards, are one of the most closely watched Oscar precursors. Actors make up the largest slice of the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences and their choices at the Actor Awards often align.

The victory for Ryan Coogler's blues-soaked vampire saga showed that it has a strong chance to win at the Oscars, too, despite an almost unblemished run of awards for Paul Thomas Anderson's 'One Battle After Another'. It's won at the Golden Globes, the Producers Guild Awards, the BAFTAs and the Directors Guild Awards.

But the win on Sunday, in a Netflix-streamed ceremony at the Shine Auditorium in Los Angeles, flipped that awards-season script. Writer-director Ryan Coogler, whose 'Black Panther' triumphed at the guild's awards in 2019, became the first filmmaker to steer two ensembles to the guild's top prize. "From the bottom of our hearts to the bottom of your hearts, thank you so much for everything," said Delroy Lindo, who spoke on behalf of the film's cast.

Moments earlier, Michael B Jordan also won best male actor, upsetting the category favourite, Timothee Chalamet and handing the 39-year-old Jordan the most sig-

nificant prize of his acclaimed career. Even Jordan looked shocked as the audience rose to its feet and Viola Davis, the award's presenter, celebrated. "I wasn't expecting this at all," said Jordan, who reflected on starting out as an actor before he paused to appreciate the moment. "Yeah, man, this is pretty cool."

As expected, Jessie Buckley won best female actor for her performance in 'Hamnet'. But the other actor races have been harder to call.

Sean Penn (who didn't attend) won best supporting male actor for 'One Battle After Another' and Amy Madigan won best supporting

Michael B Jordan also won best male actor, upsetting the category favourite, Timothee Chalamet

female actor for 'Weapons'. The 75-year-old Madigan, who had never before been nominated by the guild, was visibly surprised. Partway through her winding and charming acceptance speech, she looked down at the statuette.

Catherine O'Hara posthumously won best female actor in a comedy series for her performance as a movie executive in the showbiz satire 'The Studio'. O'Hara died at the age of 71 on January 30 from a blood clot in the lungs. At the Shine Auditorium in Los Angeles, the crowd stood

in a standing ovation for O'Hara after she was announced as the winner.

Seth Rogen, co-creator of 'The Studio', accepted the award on her behalf. He recalled a passionate collaborator who would, the night before a scene, invariably send a polite email with suggested rewrites. Rogen said O'Hara 'showed that you could be a genius and you could be kind.' "If you have people in your lives who don't know her work, show them O'Hara dancing to Harry Belafonte in 'Beetlejuice'. Show them O'Hara hurting her knee in 'Best in

Show' and doing that amazing thing where she hobbles around and tells the people, as they are laughing, that that's Catherine O'Hara. We were lucky that we got to live in a world where she so generously shared her talents with us," said Rogen.

Before the ceremony began, the award for best stunt ensemble went to a 'Paramount' release: 'Mission: Impossible - The Final Reckoning'. Among the TV awards, 'The Studio' won for comedy series and 'The Pitt' won for drama series. Individual winners included Keri Russell ('The Diplomat'), Rogen ('The Studio'), Michelle Williams ('Dying for Sex'), Owen Cooper ('Adolescence') and Noah Wyle ('The Pitt'). AGENCIES

